

ANSWERS & EXPLANATIONS

GENERAL STUDIES (P) TEST –3795 (2023)

Q 1.D

- **The Election Commission** registers political parties for the purpose of elections and grants them **recognition as national or state parties** on the **basis of their poll performance**. The other parties are simply declared as registered-unrecognized parties.
- **Recognition as a national party ensures:**
 - **The election symbol of that party cannot be used by any other political party in polls across India. Hence option 4 is correct.**
 - Recognized 'National' party requires **only one proposer** to file a nomination. **Hence option 1 is correct.**
 - The recognized National Parties are given **two sets of electoral rolls free of cost** by the Election Commission. In addition to this the candidates contesting on the ticket of National or state party get a copy of the electoral roll free of cost during the general elections. **Hence option 2 is correct.**
 - The National parties receive **land or building from the government** to establish their party office. **Hence option 3 is correct.**
 - The National parties can have upto **40 star campaigners**.
 - National Parties get the **time slot on the national and state television & Radio** to address the people and convey their message to the mass people.

Q 2.D

- The Constitution of India (**Article 148**) provides for an independent office of the Comptroller and Auditor General of India (CAG).
- He is the head of the Indian Audit and Accounts Department. He is the guardian of the public purse and controls the entire financial system of the country at both the levels—the Centre and the state.
 - He assist the Public Accounts Committee (PAC) of the Parliament. In fact, the CAG acts as a guide, friend and philosopher of the committee. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- His duty is to uphold the Constitution of India and laws of Parliament in the field of financial administration. The CAG is appointed by the president of India by a warrant under his hand and seal. The CAG, before taking over his office, makes and subscribes before the president an oath or affirmation.
- He holds office for a period of six years or upto the age of 65 years, whichever is earlier.
- **He can resign** any time from his office by addressing the resignation letter to the President.
- He can also be removed by the president on same grounds and in the same manner as a judge of the Supreme Court. In other words, **he can be removed by the president only in accordance with the procedure mentioned in the Constitution**. Thus, he does not hold his office till the pleasure of the president, though he is appointed by him. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- He is not eligible for further office, either under the Government of India or of any state, after he ceases to hold his office.
- His salary and other service conditions are determined by the Parliament. **His salary is equal to that of a judge of the Supreme Court. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- No minister can represent the CAG in Parliament (both Houses) and no minister can be called upon to take any responsibility for any actions done by him.

Q 3.C

- **Eighth Schedule:** Originally, it had 14 languages but presently there are 22 languages.
 - They are: Assamese, Bengali, Bodo, Dogri (Dongri), Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Kashmiri, Konkani, Mathili (Maithili), Malayalam, Manipuri, Marathi, Nepali, Odia, Punjabi, Sanskrit, Santhali, Sindhi, Tamil, Telugu and Urdu.
 - **Sindhi** was added by the 21st Amendment Act of 1967;

- **Konkani**, Manipuri and Nepali were added by the 71st Amendment Act of 1992; and
- Bodo, Dongri, **Maithili** and **Santhali** were added by the 92nd Amendment Act of 2003. Oriya was renamed as 'Odia' by the 96th Amendment Act of 2011.
- **Hence option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 4.C

- A **Social Audit** is defined as a **process in which details of the resources, both financial and non-financial used by the Public Agency for the development initiatives, are shared with the public through a public platform**. It is a legally mandated process where potential and existing beneficiaries evaluate the implementation of a programme by comparing official records with ground realities. This aspect allows the clientele to enforce transparency and accountability by scrutinizing the development activities which also enables them to participate in the development process. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- Social audits are **supervised by autonomous bodies consisting of government and non-government representatives along with the local beneficiaries**.
- **Meghalaya became the first state in the country to operationalise a law, The Meghalaya Community Participation and Public Services Social Audit Act, 2017, which makes social audit of State-run schemes mandatory**. Many states have set up an independent Social Audit Unit (SAU) and some have even begun to facilitate Social Audit in other programmes, including Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, National Social Assistance Programme, Midday Meal Scheme and Public Distribution System.
- **The Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee Act (MGNREGA) was the first law to mandate social audit as a statutory requirement. MGNREGA Audit of Schemes Rules was passed by the Central Government, in consultation with the Comptroller and Auditor General (C&AG) in 2011**. Under MGNREGA scheme rules, apart from the ongoing process of social audit, it has mandated to convene Social Audit Forum once in every six months, which will serve as an institutional forum where people can conduct details public audit of all MGNREGA works that have been carried out in their area in the preceding six months. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**

Q 5.B

- As per the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, a person who buys any goods or services for a consideration, which has been paid or promised or partly paid and partly promised, or under any system of deferred payment also includes the user with approval of such goods or beneficiary of services is considered a 'consumer'.
- As per Consumer Protection Act 2019, the expression “buys any goods” and ‘hires or avails any services’ includes offline or online transactions through electronic means or by teleshopping or direct selling or multi-level marketing.
 - **A person who obtains goods for resale or for any commercial purposes and who avails services for any commercial purposes is not considered a 'consumer' under the rules of the Act. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
 - As per the provisions of the act, commercial purpose does not include use by a person of goods bought and used by him exclusively for the purposes of earning his livelihood by means of self-employment.
- Consumer Disputes Redressal Agencies are quasi-judicial bodies established under the Act to provide simple, speedy, and inexpensive redressal to the grievances of consumers.
 - These have been established at three levels: District, State, and National, known as District Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission or District Commission, State Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission or State Commission, and National Consumer Disputes Redressal Commission or National Commission.
- The Central Authority i.e. **the Central Consumer Protection Authority may inquire or cause an inquiry or investigation to be made into violations of Consumer Rights, either suo-moto or on a complaint received or on the directions from the Central Government. Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- **Every complaint filed with the commission is accompanied by a fee.** The fee for filing a complaint varies for all three commissions at the District, State, and National levels with the value of goods and services paid as consideration. **Hence statement 3 is not correct.**

Q 6.D

- **The implementation of nationwide portability of ration cards through the ‘One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC)’ scheme, is an endeavour of the Department of Food & Public Distribution, under the Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution to empower about 81 crore beneficiaries.** This plan has been launched under the National Food Security Act (NFSA), 2013, which aims to ensure that anyone can take their share of food grains from any district of any state of the country. **Hence statement 3 is not correct.**

- Through this facility, while a migrant beneficiary is able to get ration at the destination he or she is working in, his/her family back home is also allowed to get their part of the entitled ration to support itself. **This system provides flexibility to all NFSA beneficiaries to lift their foodgrains from any FPS (Fair Price Shop) of their choice. Under the ONORC (One Nation, One Ration Card), beneficiaries covered under the National Food Security Act, 2013 (NFSA) can get their quota of subsidized foodgrains from any electronic point of sale device (ePoS)-enabled fair price shops of their choice by using their existing ration cards with biometric authentication.**
 - NFSA covers up to 75% of the rural population and 50% of the urban population under Antyodaya Anna Yojana (AAY) and priority households. While AAY households, which constitute the poorest of the poor are entitled to 35 kg of foodgrains per family per month, priority households are entitled to 5 kg per person per month. **Through the OORC program, all eligible ration card holders/beneficiaries covered under NFSA can access their entitlements from anywhere in the country and not just the BPL category. Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- **Recently, Assam has become the 36th state/UT to implement ONORC. With this, the ONORC programme has been successfully implemented in all states and Union Territories, making food security portable throughout the country. Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 7.A

- **The original Constitution did not contain provisions with respect to the tribunals. Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- **The 42nd Amendment Act of 1976 added a new Part XIV-A to the Constitution. This part is entitled as 'Tribunals' and consists of only two Articles:**
 - **Article 323-A dealing with administrative tribunals and**
 - **Article 323-B dealing with tribunals for other matters.**
- Article 323-A empowers the **Parliament** to provide for the establishment of administrative tribunals for the adjudication of disputes relating to recruitment and conditions of service of persons appointed to **public services of the Centre, the states, local bodies**, public corporations, and other public authorities. In other words, Article 323-A enables the Parliament to take out the adjudication of disputes relating to service matters from the civil courts and the high courts and place it **before the administrative tribunals. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- In pursuance of **Article 323-A**, the Parliament has passed the **Administrative Tribunals Act in 1985**. The act authorises the **Central government to establish one Central administrative tribunal and the state administrative tribunals**. This act opened a new chapter in the sphere of providing speedy and inexpensive justice to the aggrieved public servants.
- **Under Article 323-B, the Parliament and the state legislatures are authorised to provide for the establishment of tribunals for the adjudication of disputes relating to the following matters:**
 - Taxation
 - Foreign exchange, import and export
 - Industrial and labour
 - Land reforms
 - Ceiling on urban property
 - Elections to Parliament and state legislatures
 - Food stuff
 - Rent and tenancy rights

Q 8.D

- Recently, the Department of School Education and Literacy, Ministry of Education released the National Achievement Survey (NAS)2021 report.
- **National Achievement Survey (NAS)** is a nationally representative large-scale survey of students' learning undertaken by the **Ministry of Education, Government of India. The National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT)** has developed the Assessment Framework for gauging the competencies attained by the students vis-a-vis learning outcomes.
- The Survey goes beyond the scorecard and includes the background variables to correlate students' performance in different learning outcomes vis-a-vis contextual variables.
- This national-level survey is **conducted by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) as Assessment Administrator for Grade 3, 5, 8 and 10 students of State Govt. schools, Govt. Aided schools, Private Unaided recognized schools and Central Government schools. Hence, statements 1 and 2 are not correct.**

- The **Annual Status of Education Report (ASER)** is a **household-based rather than school-based survey**. This design enables all children to be included – those who have never been to school or have dropped out, as well as those who are in government schools, private schools, religious schools or anywhere else. But **NAS is conducted in a monitored environment in the sampled schools. Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**

Q 9.C

- **The National Legal Services Authority (NALSA) has been constituted under the Legal Services Authorities Act, 1987** to provide free Legal Services to the weaker sections of society and to organize Lok Adalats for amicable settlement of disputes.
- **The Chief Justice of India is the Patron-in-Chief.** NALSA is housed at the Supreme Court of India, New Delhi
- National Legal Services Authority is the apex body constituted to lay down policies and principles for making legal services available under the provisions of the Act and to frame the most effective and economical schemes for legal services. **It also disburses funds and grants to State Legal Services Authorities and NGOs for implementing legal aid schemes and programs. Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- **Section 12** of the Legal Services Authorities Act, 1987 prescribes the criteria for giving legal services to eligible persons., they are:-
 - Member of Scheduled Caste or Scheduled Tribe
 - victim of human trafficking or a beggar
 - woman or child; or if the individual suffers from any disability. **A woman is entitled to free legal aid irrespective of her income or financial status while a child is eligible for free legal aid till the age of majority i.e. 18 years. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
 - victim of mass disaster, ethnic violence, caste atrocity, flood, drought, earthquake, industrial disaster
 - an industrial workman;
 - A person in custody, including protective custody; or facing a charge which might result in imprisonment.
 - a person in receipt of annual income less than the amount prescribed by the State Government, if the case is before a Court other than the Supreme Court, and less than Rs 5 Lakh, if the case is before the Supreme Court.
- Legal Services Authorities after examining the eligibility criteria of an applicant and the existence of a prima facie case in his favor provide him counsel at State expense, pay the required court fee in the matter and bear all incidental expenses in connection with the case. The person to whom legal aid is provided is not called upon to spend anything on the litigation once it is supported by a Legal Services Authority.

Q 10.B

- The Directorate of Enforcement or the ED is a multi-disciplinary organization mandated to investigate economic crimes and violations of foreign exchange laws. The origin of this Directorate goes back to 1st May 1956, when an 'Enforcement Unit' was formed in the Department of Economic Affairs for handling Exchange Control Laws violations under Foreign Exchange Regulation Act, 1947 (FERA '47).
- In the year 1957, this Unit was renamed as 'Enforcement Directorate'. Presently, the Directorate is under the administrative control of the Department of Revenue, Ministry of Finance, Government of India.
- With the onset of the process of economic liberalization, FERA, 1973, which was a regulatory law, was repealed and in its place, a new law viz. the Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999 (FEMA) came into operation w.e.f. 1st June 2000. **Further, in tune with the International Anti-Money Laundering regime, the Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA) was enacted, and ED was entrusted with its enforcement w.e.f. 1st July 2005.** Recently, with the increase in the number of cases relating to economic offenders taking shelter in foreign countries, the Government has passed the Fugitive Economic Offenders Act, 2018 (FEOA), and ED is entrusted with its enforcement with effect from 21st April 2018. **Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- The ED is the only central investigative agency that does not require permission from the government or any authority to summon or prosecute politicians or government officials for inquiry into economic offenses and financial crimes like money laundering. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- **The Prevention of Money Laundering Act, 2002 (PMLA):**
 - It is a criminal law enacted to prevent money laundering and to provide for confiscation of property derived from, or involved in, money-laundering and for matters connected therewith or incidental thereto.

- ED has been given the responsibility to enforce the provisions of the PMLA by conducting an investigation to trace the assets derived from proceeds of crime, provisionally attach the property, and ensuring the prosecution of the offenders and confiscation of the property by the Special court.
- ED can start an investigation against anyone without complaint or application. An ED officer does not even have to file a First Information Report (FIR).
- The FIR is a mandatory provision under the Criminal Procedure Code and the Indian Penal Code. Without an FIR, an investigating officer does not have the authority to proceed with an investigation. However, under the PMLA, an officer just needs to file an Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR) which is for internal use and need not be shared with the accused.
- **The PMLA gives authority to an investigating officer to arrest an accused without prior intimation, even without sharing the ECIR. An investigating officer can also issue summons without giving any specific reason. Hence statement 2 is correct.**

Q 11.D

- **None of the Above (NOTA)** is a ballot option designed to allow voters to **indicate disapproval of all of the candidates** in a voting system **without violation of the secrecy** of their decision.
- The **Supreme Court of India on September 27, 2013**, ruled that the right to register a 'none of the above' vote in elections should apply while ordering the Election Commission of India (ECI) to provide a button for the same in the electronic voting machines.
- The NOTA option was first used in the 2013 assembly elections held in four states -- Chhattisgarh, Mizoram, Rajasthan, and Madhya Pradesh, and the Union Territory, Delhi.
- **NOTA is not right to reject i.e. candidate with maximum votes wins** the election irrespective of the number of NOTA votes polled. Election Commission also has clarified that even though votes cast as NOTA are counted, they are **considered invalid votes** so they will not change the outcome of election process.
- **Hence, option (d) is the correct answer.**

Q 12.A

- **Public-Private Partnership (PPP)** means an arrangement between a Government / statutory entity / Government owned entity on one side and a private sector entity on the other, for the provision of public assets and/or public services, through investments being made and/or management being undertaken by the private sector entity, for a specified period of time, where there is well-defined allocation of risk between the private sector and the public entity and the private entity who is chosen on the basis of open competitive bidding, receives performance-linked payments that conform (or are benchmarked) to specified and pre-determined performance standards, measurable by the public entity or its representative.
- The most common form of PPP used is **BOT (Build-Operate-Transfer)** where the private sector operator designs, builds, finances, owns and constructs the facility and operates it commercially for the concession period, after which the facility is transferred to the authority. In this case, legal ownership of the asset vests with the public sector as the concession period ends. The most common form of a BOT project is a Toll Road project. **Hence option (a) is the correct answer.**
- **Operations & Maintenance (Service contract):** the Government bids out the right to deliver a specific service or gives part of the undertaking to the private sector for operations and maintenance of the assets. Such contracts are normally of a shorter duration than concession contracts.
- **Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC):** This is a PPP model for the development of infrastructure projects, especially highways. Under this model, the cost is completely borne by the government. Government invites bids for engineering knowledge from private players. Procurement of raw materials and construction costs are met by the government. The private sector's participation is minimum and is limited to the provision of engineering expertise. A difficulty of the model is that financial is a high financial burden for the government.

Q 13.B

- **National e-Governance Plan (NeGP)** was formulated in 2006 by the Department of Administrative Reforms & Public Grievances (DARPG), Ministry of Electronics & Information Technology (ME&IT), and Ministry of Personnel, Public Grievances & Pensions. **Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- The ultimate objective is to bring public services closer home to citizens, as articulated in the Vision Statement of NeGP. The Government approved the National e-Governance Plan (NeGP), comprising of 27 Mission Mode Projects and 8 components, on May 18, 2006. In the year 2011, 4 projects - Health, Education, PDS and Posts were introduced to make the list of 27 MMPs to 31 Mission Mode Projects (MMPs).

- The Government has accorded approval to the vision, approach, strategy, key components, implementation methodology, and management structure for NeGP. **However, the approval of NeGP does not constitute financial approval(s) for all the Mission Mode Projects (MMPs) and components under it.**
- The **major core infrastructure components of the National e-Governance Plan are State Data Centres (SDCs), State Wide Area Networks (S.W.A.N), Common Services Centres (CSCs)** and middleware gateways i.e. National e-Governance Service Delivery Gateway (NSDG), State e-Governance Service Delivery Gateway (SSDG), and Mobile e-Governance Service Delivery Gateway (MSDG). **Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- NeGP 2.0: NeGP 2.0 or e-Kranti was introduced by the government in March 2015 under the Digital India program to utilise emerging technologies such as cloud, mobile platforms (like smartphones and tablets) and geospatial information systems.

Q 14.C

- Recently NASA has said is planning to shut down SOFIA telescope that found water on Moon.
- **SOFIA, the Stratospheric Observatory for Infrared Astronomy, is a Boeing 747SP aircraft modified to carry a 2.7-meter (106-inch) reflecting telescope.** Flying into the stratosphere at 38,000-45,000 feet puts SOFIA above 99 percent of Earth's infrared-blocking atmosphere, allowing astronomers to study the solar system and beyond in ways that are not possible with ground-based telescopes.
 - **SOFIA is made possible through a partnership between NASA and the German Space Agency. Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- The observatory's mobility allows researchers to observe from almost anywhere in the world, and enables studies of transient events that often take place over oceans where there are no telescopes. For example, astronomers on SOFIA studied eclipse-like events of Pluto, Saturn's moon Titan, and Kuiper Belt Object MU69, the next flyby target for NASA's New Horizons spacecraft, to study the objects' atmospheres and surroundings.
- SOFIA is designed to observe the infrared universe. Many objects in space emit almost all their energy at infrared wavelengths and are often invisible when observed with visible light. In other cases, celestial clouds of gas and dust block the light emitted by more distant objects, but infrared energy pierces through these clouds. In both cases, the only way to learn about these objects is to study the infrared light they emit.
- **SOFIA's telescope instruments — cameras, spectrometers, and polarimeters — operate in the near-, mid- and far-infrared wavelengths, each suited to studying a particular phenomena. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
 - Spectrometers spread light into its component colors, in the same way that a prism spreads visible light into a rainbow, to reveal the chemical fingerprints of celestial molecules and atoms.
 - Polarimeters are sensitive to the effect magnetic fields have on dust in and around celestial objects, allowing astronomers to learn how magnetic fields affect the birth of stars and other objects.
- **Unlike space-based telescopes, SOFIA lands after each flight, so its instruments can be exchanged, serviced or upgraded to harness new technologies.** Because these new instruments can be tested and adjusted, SOFIA can explore new frontiers in the solar system and beyond and serve as a testbed for technology that may one day fly in space. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**

Q 15.C

- The Cabinet Secretariat functions directly under the Prime Minister. **Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- The administrative head of the Secretariat is the Cabinet Secretary who is also the ex-officio Chairman of the Civil Services Board. The business allocated to Cabinet Secretariat under Government of India (Allocation of Business) Rules, 1961 includes
 - Secretarial assistance to the Cabinet and Cabinet Committees; and
 - Rules of Business.
- The Cabinet Secretariat is responsible for the administration of the Government of India (Transaction of Business) Rules, 1961 and Government of India (Allocation of Business) Rules, 1961 facilitating smooth transaction of business in Ministries/ Departments. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- The Cabinet Secretariat ensures that the President, the Vice President and Ministers are kept informed of the major activities of all Ministries/Departments by means of monthly summary of their activities. Management of major crisis situations in the country and coordinating activities of various Ministries in such a situation is also one of the functions of the Cabinet Secretariat. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- The secretarial assistance, provided by Cabinet Secretariat to the Cabinet and Cabinet committees, includes
 - Convening of the meetings of the Cabinet & its Committees on the orders of the Prime Minister.
 - Preparation and circulation of the agenda.

- Circulation of papers related to the cases on the agenda.
- Preparation of record of discussions. Circulation of the record of discussions after obtaining the approval of the Prime Minister.
- Monitoring implementation of decisions taken by the Cabinet and its Committees.
- The Cabinet Secretariat is the custodian of the papers of the Cabinet meetings.

Q 16.C

- **Sevottam is a “Service Delivery Excellence Model” which provides an assessment-improvement framework to bring about excellence in public service delivery.** The term “Sevottam” is formed by joining two Hindi words “seva” and “uttam” meaning “service” and “excellence” respectively.
- **It’s first component, the citizen’s charter** publicly declares the information on citizens’ entitlements thereby making them better informed and hence empowering them to demand better services. **Hence option 2 is correct.**
- **The second component of the model, “Public Grievance Redress”** requires a good grievance redressal system operating in a manner that leaves the citizen more satisfied with how the organisation responds to complaints/grievances, irrespective of the final decision. **Hence option 4 is correct.**
- **The third component of the model, “Service Delivery Capability”** postulates that an organisation can have an excellent performance in service delivery only if it is efficiently managing the key ingredients for good service delivery and building its own capacity to continuously improve upon service delivery. **Hence option 1 is correct.**
- Information and Communication Technology (ICT), can be a facilitator to sevottam model, however it is not a mandatory condition for excellent service delivery. **Hence option 3 is not correct.**

Q 17.A

- **Nagpur Resolution- A Holistic Approach for Empowering Citizens’ was adopted during the session on ‘Improving Public Service Delivery – Role of Governments’** in Nagpur, Maharashtra.
 - The conference was organized by the Department of Administrative Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG), Government of India, in collaboration with the Government of Maharashtra and the Maharashtra State Commission for Right to Public Services.
- **The Nagpur Resolution aimed to empower the citizens by policy interventions for better service delivery through timely updation of citizens charters, implementation of enactments, and benchmarking standards for continuous improvement. Hence option (a) is the correct answer.**
- **Similarly, the Shillong Declaration and the Jammu Resolution have been adopted during different conferences of the DARPG to ensure Good Governance** across the states and enable citizen-centric machinery via digital and electronic modes of service delivery.

Q 18.B

- **Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT)**
 - The Central Administrative Tribunal (CAT) was **set up in 1985** with the principal bench in Delhi and additional benches in different states. At present, it has 17 regular benches, 15 of which operate at the principal seats of high courts and the remaining two at Jaipur and Lucknow.
 - The CAT exercises original jurisdiction in relation to recruitment and all service matters of public servants covered by it. Its jurisdiction extends to the all-India services, the Central civil services, civil posts under the Centre and civilian employees of defence services. However, the members of the defence forces, officers and servants of the Supreme Court and the secretarial staff of the Parliament are not covered by it.
 - At present (2019), the sanctioned strength of the Chairman is one and sanctioned strength of the Members is 65. **They are drawn from both judicial and administrative streams and are appointed by the President.** They hold office for a term of five years or until they attain the age of 65 years in the case of the chairman and 62 years in the case of members, whichever is earlier. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
 - The appointment of Members in CAT is made on the basis of recommendations of a high-powered selection committee chaired by a sitting Judge of the Supreme Court who is nominated by the Chief Justice of India. After obtaining the concurrence of the Chief Justice of India, appointments are made with the approval of the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC).
 - **The CAT is not bound by the procedure laid down in the Civil Procedure Code of 1908.** It is guided by the principles of natural justice. These principles keep the CAT flexible in its approach. Only a nominal fee of ₹50 is to be paid by the applicant. The applicant may appear either in person or through a lawyer. **Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**

- **Originally, appeals against the orders of the CAT could be made only in the Supreme Court and not in the high courts. However, in the Chandra Kumar case (1997), the Supreme Court declared this restriction on the jurisdiction of the high courts unconstitutional, holding that judicial review is a part of the basic structure of the Constitution. It laid down that appeals against the orders of the CAT shall lie before the division bench of the concerned high court. Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 19.C

- A restricted set of voters can exercise **postal voting**. Through this facility, a voter can cast her vote remotely by recording her preference on the ballot paper and sending it back to the election officer before counting.
- Any **absentee voter** wishing to vote by postal ballot has to **make an application to the returning officer in Form-12D**, giving all required particulars, and get the application verified by the nodal officer appointed by the organization concerned.
- Recently, the Election Commission of India (ECI) has **allowed journalists to cast their votes through a postal ballot facility**. Currently, the following voters are also allowed to cast their votes through postal ballot: **Service voters** (armed forces, the armed police force of a state, and government servants posted abroad), **Voters on election duty**, **Voters above 80 years of age or Persons with Disabilities (PwD)** and **Voters under preventive detention**. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- ECI has clarified that any voter opting for a postal ballot would not be able to cast a normal vote at a polling station. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Q 20.B

- The National Investigation Agency (NIA) came into existence with the enactment of the National Investigation Agency Act 2008 by the Parliament of India on December 31, 2008.
- NIA is working as the Central Counter-Terrorism Law Enforcement Agency in India.
- According to National Investigation Agency (Amendment) Act, 2019, officers of the **NIA will have the power to investigate scheduled offenses committed outside India, subject to international treaties and domestic laws of other countries. Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- National Investigation Agency Act 2008 gives the **NIA powers to take suo-moto cognizance of terror activities in any part of India and register a case, to enter any state without permission from the state government, and to investigate and arrest people. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- National Investigation Agency (Amendment) Act, 2019 has allowed the NIA to investigate, **additional cases** related to
 - **human trafficking, hence statement 3 is correct.**
 - counterfeit currency or banknotes,
 - manufacture or sale of prohibited arms,
 - cyber-terrorism, and
 - offenses under the Explosive Substances Act, 1908.

Q 21.A

- **The salient features of the Lokpal and Lokayuktas Act (2013):**
 - It seeks to establish the institution of the Lokpal at the Centre and the Lokayukta at the level of the State and thus seeks to provide a uniform vigilance and anti-corruption road map for the nation both at the Centre and at the States.
 - The jurisdiction of Lokpal includes **the Prime Minister, Ministers, Members of Parliament, and Groups A, B, C, and D officers** and officials of the Central Government.
 - The Lokpal to consists of a Chairperson with a maximum of 8 members of which 50% shall be judicial members.
 - 50% of the members of the Lokpal shall come from amongst the SCs, the STs, the OBCs, minorities, and women.
 - The selection of the Chairperson and the members of Lokpal shall be through a Selection Committee consisting of the Prime Minister, the Speaker of the Lok Sabha, the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha, the Chief Justice of India or a sitting Supreme Court Judge nominated by the Chief Justice of India and an eminent jurist to be nominated by the President of India on the basis of recommendations of the first four members of the selection committee.
 - The Lokpal will have the power of superintendence and direction over any investigating agency, including the CBI, for cases referred to them by the Lokpal.
 - **It provides adequate protection for honest and upright public servants. Hence option (b) is correct.**

- All entities receiving donations from foreign sources in the context of the Foreign Contribution Regulation Act (FCRA) in excess of Rs.10 lakhs per year are brought under the jurisdiction of Lokpal.
- Institutions that are financed fully or partly by the Government are under the jurisdiction of Lokpal, but **institutions aided by Government are excluded. Hence option (d) is correct.**
- **It provides legal assistance to public servants against whom the complaint is filed. Hence option (c) is correct.**
- **Lokpal cannot suo-moto proceed against any public servant. Hence option (a) is not correct.**
- Anonymous complaints are not allowed – Can't just make a complaint on plain paper and drop it in a box with supporting documents.

Q 22.C

- **Section 8 of the Representation of the People Act (RPA, 1951) provides the grounds on which a person is disqualified** from contesting elections in case he/she has been **convicted** for the following offenses:
 - **Promoting enmity** between different groups of people divided on the **basis of caste, color, religion, place of birth, etc.** and disrupting an environment of harmony.
 - for the offense of bribery and undue influence or personation in elections respectively.
 - Offense of **rape**
 - making **controversial and hate-provoking statements** related to religion, communities, or classes
 - Promoting or preaching the traditional **practice of 'untouchability'** which is abolished completely under Article 17 of Indian Constitution
 - Insulting the **National Honour Act, 1971.**
- A conviction for an offense of **robbery (section 390 of the Indian Penal Code)** is **not a ground for disqualification** of electoral candidates under the Representation of People Act (RPA) 1951.
- **Hence, option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 23.B

- The Constitution makes a provision for the establishment of a Joint State Public Service Commission (JSPSC) for two or more states. While the UPSC and the SPSC are created directly by the Constitution, a JSPSC can be created by an act of Parliament on the request of the state legislatures concerned. Thus, **a JSPSC is a statutory and not a constitutional body.** The two states of Punjab and Haryana had a JSPSC for a short period, after the creation of Haryana out of Punjab in 1966.
- The chairman and members of a JSPSC are appointed by the President. **Hence option (b) is the correct answer.**
 - They hold office for a term of six years or until they attain the age of 62 years, whichever is earlier.
 - They can be suspended or removed by the president.
 - They can also resign from their offices at any time by submitting their resignation letters to the president.
- The number of members of a JSPSC and their conditions of service are determined by the **President.**
- A JSPSC presents its annual performance report to each of the **concerned state governors.** Each governor places the report before the state legislature.

Q 24.A

- Right to Information Act, 2005 was enacted to provide for setting out the practical regime of right to information for citizens to secure access to information under the control of public authorities, in order to promote transparency and accountability in the working of every public authority, the constitution of a Central Information Commission and state Information Commissions and for matters connected therewith or incidental thereto.
- Only the citizens of India have the right to seek information under the provisions of the Right to Information Act 2005. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- According to the Act, every government organization is needed to appoint one employee as a public information officer (PIO).
 - Once a department gets an RTI request, it is the responsibility of the PIO to furnish the information to the applicant within 30 days. Failing to do so means a monetary fine can be imposed on the PIO.
 - However, sometimes government records are misplaced or missing. Or the agency one has written to needs to co-ordinate with another department to provide the information. In such situations, the information may take more than 30 days to arrive. In such a case, the PIO concerned needs to send a written intimation to the applicant about the possible delay and the reason.
 - If he/she fails to do so, a penalty can be levied on the PIO and the matter can be taken up with appellate authorities. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 25.D

- **The Competition Commission of India (CCI) is a statutory body of the Government of India responsible for enforcing the Competition Act, 2002. Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
 - The Competition Act, 2002 prohibits anti-competitive agreements, abuse of dominant position by enterprises and regulates combinations (acquisition, acquiring of control and mergers & acquisitions), which causes or likely to cause an appreciable adverse effect on competition within India.
- It is the duty of the Commission to eliminate practices having adverse effect on competition, promote and sustain competition, protect the interests of consumers and ensure freedom of trade in the markets of India.
- The Commission is also required to give opinion on competition issues on a reference received from a statutory authority established under any law and to undertake competition advocacy, create public awareness and impart training on competition issues.
- Under Section 8(2) of the Competition Act, 2002, the Chairperson and every other Member shall be a person of ability, integrity and standing and who, has been, or is qualified to be a judge of a High Court, or, has special knowledge of, and professional experience of not less than fifteen years in international trade, economics, business, commerce, law, finance, accountancy, management, industry, public affairs, administration or in any other matter which, in the opinion of the Central Government, may be useful to the Commission. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**
- Under Section 410 of the Companies Act, 2013 and Section 53A(1) of the Competition Act, 2002, **the government replaced the Competition Appellate Tribunal (COMPAT) with the National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) in 2017. Hence statement 3 is not correct.**

Q 26.D

- The National Commission for Safai Karamcharis (NCSK) was constituted on 12th August, 1994 as a statutory body by an Act of Parliament viz. **‘National Commission for Safai Karamcharis Act, 1993’, for a period of three years** i.e. up to 31st March, 1997. As per sub-section (4) of Section 1 of the Act, it was to cease to exist after 31.3.1997. However, validity of the Act was extended up to March, 2002, and then up to February, 2004 vide Amendment Acts passed in 1997 and 2001 respectively. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**
 - **With the lapsing of the “The National Commission for Safai Karamcharis Act, 1993” w.e.f. 29.2.2004, the Commission is acting as a Non-Statutory body of the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment. Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- **The mandate of the National Commission for Safai Karamcharis:**
 - Recommend to the Central Government specific programmes of action towards elimination of inequalities in status, facilities and opportunities for Safai Karamcharis.
 - Study and evaluate the implementation of the programmes and schemes relating to the social and economic rehabilitation of Safai Karamcharis; and scavengers, in particular.
 - Investigate specific grievances and take suo-motu notice of matters relating to non-implementation of:-
 - ✓ programmes or schemes in respect of any group of Safai Karamcharis
 - ✓ decisions, guidelines or instructions, aimed at mitigating the hardships of Safai Karamcharis
 - ✓ measures for the social and economic upliftment of Safai Karamcharis
 - ✓ the provisions of any law in its application to Safai Karamcharis; and take up such matters with the concerned authorities or with the Central or State Governments.
 - To study and monitor the working conditions, including those relating to health, safety and wages of Safai Karamcharis working under various kinds of employers including Government, Municipalities and Panchayats, and to make recommendations in this regard.
 - **However, with the enactment of “The Prohibition of Employment as Manual Scavengers and Their Rehabilitation Act, 2013”, the mandate and scope of the Commission has also been enlarged.** Such as:
 - ✓ To monitor the implementation of the Act.
 - ✓ To enquire into complaints regarding contravention of the provisions of the Act, and to convey its findings to the concerned authorities with recommendations requiring further action.
 - ✓ To advise the Central and the State Governments for effective implementation of the provisions of the Act.
 - ✓ To take suo motu notice of matter relating to non-implementation of the Act.
- **National Safai Karamcharis Finance & Development Corporation (NSKFDC):**
 - A wholly owned Govt. of India Undertaking under the Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment was set up on 24th January 1997 as a Company “Not for Profit” under Section 25 of the Companies Act, 1956.

- NSKFDC is in operation since October, 1997, as an Apex Corporation for the all round socio-economic upliftment of the Safai Karamcharis, Scavengers and their dependents throughout India, through various loan and non-loan based schemes.
- Apart from operating various loan and non-loan based schemes for the upliftment of the target group, NSKFDC is playing a vital role in elimination of manual scavenging - **the worst surviving symbol of untouchability.**
- NSKFDC has been designated as the Nodal Agency for implementation of the Central Sector **Self Employment Scheme for Rehabilitation of Manual Scavengers (SRMS)** under the aegis of the Ministry of Social Justice & Empowerment. **Hence statement 3 is not correct.**

Q 27.A

- Good Governance Index is a comprehensive and implementable framework to assess the State of Governance across the States and UTs which enables the ranking of States/Districts. The objective of GGI is to create a tool which can be used uniformly across the States to assess the impact of various interventions taken up by the Central and State Governments including UTs.
- Following the recommendation of the GoS on Governance, **the Department of Administration Reforms and Public Grievances (DARPG), the Government of India launched the Good Governance Index (GGI) Framework and published the ranking for the States and Union Territories (UTs) for 2019 on the occasion of Good Governance Day, i.e., 25 December 2019. Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- The GGI 2019 encompassed 10 Governance Sectors and 50 Governance Indicators. For GGI 2020-21, the same 10 Governance Sectors were retained while indicators have been revised to 58.

Nos. of Indicators: GGI 2019 and 2020-21

#	Sectors	No. of Indicators	
		2019	2020-21
1	Agriculture and Allied Sector	6	8
2	Commerce and Industry	3	5
3	Human Resource Development	6	7
4	Public Health	6	6
5	Public Infrastructure and Utilities	9	6
6	Economic Governance	4	4
7	Social Welfare and Development	8	10
8	Judiciary and Public Safety	5	5
9	Environment	2	4
10	Citizen Centric Governance	1	3
	Total	50	58

- As observed from the table, **all ten sectors are evaluated on a different number of indicators as a part of the Good Governance Index. Hence statement 3 is not correct.**
- **The Good Governance Index is envisaged as a bi-annual exercise. Hence statement 2 is correct.**

Q 28.B

- **Concept of Sovereign immunity:** Sovereign immunity, or state immunity, is a principle of customary international law, by virtue of which one sovereign state cannot be sued before the courts of another sovereign state without its consent. Put in another way, a sovereign state is exempt from the jurisdiction of foreign national courts.
- **India has adopted a restricted concept of sovereign immunity.** Pursuant to the Code of Civil Procedure of India, foreign states and their organs and instrumentalities can be sued with the prior written consent of

the Indian government. However, such consent may not be required where the matter is governed by a special law (for, eg, the Carriage by Air Act 1972, Consumer Protection Act 1986) or where the legal proceedings are not in the nature of a suit, such as an industrial dispute under the Industrial Disputes Act 1947.

- In its 2011 judgment in *Ethiopian Airlines v Ganesh Narain Saboo* (Ethiopian Airlines), **the Supreme Court of India reiterated the consistent view in India that the doctrine of sovereign immunity in India was not absolute. Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- Also, **the foreign states do not have immunity from judicial proceedings** in cases involving their commercial and trading activities and contractual obligations undertaken by them in India. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- **Legal basis**
- The legislative recognition of the doctrine of sovereign immunity in India can be found in the following provisions and statutes:
 - section 86 of the Code of Civil Procedure 1908 (CPC), which provides that no suit may be instituted against foreign states in India, except with the prior written consent of the government; and
 - the Diplomatic Relations (Vienna Convention) Act 1972, which incorporates certain specified immunities available to diplomatic missions and their members in India pursuant to the Vienna Convention on Diplomatic Relations, 1961. A few articles of the Convention, including articles 29, 30, 31, 32, 37, 38 and 39, have been given the force of law in India by extending the scope of sovereign immunity to diplomatic agents, their family, members of staff and servants.
- **Multilateral treaties**
 - On 12 January 2007, **India became a signatory to the UN Convention on Jurisdictional Immunities of States and Their Property, 2004.** However, it is important to emphasise that India has not proceeded to ratify this Convention and that the Convention itself is not in force yet. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 29.B

- Under Articles of Association, the board of directors of Central Public Sector Enterprises (CPSEs) enjoys autonomy in respect of recruitment, promotion and other service conditions of below-board level employees. The government has granted enhanced powers to the Boards of the profit-making enterprises under various schemes like Maharatna, Navratna and Miniratna.
- **Maharatna scheme**
 - The main objective of the Maharatna scheme which was introduced in 2010 is to empower mega CPSEs to expand their operations and emerge as global giants.
 - Maharatna CPSEs compared to others are given greater autonomy for flexibility in respect of capital expenditure, formation of strategic alliance, formulation of HR policies, etc.
 - The Board of a 'Maharatna' CPSE can make equity investments to undertake financial joint ventures and wholly-owned subsidiaries and undertake mergers and acquisitions in India and abroad, subject to a ceiling of 15 percent of the net worth of the concerned CPSE, limited to Rs 5,000 crore in one project.
 - The board can also structure and implement schemes relating to personnel and human resource management and training. They can also enter into technology joint ventures or other strategic alliances.
- **The CPSEs meeting the following eligibility criteria are considered for Maharatna status:**
 - Having Navratna status. **Hence option 1 is not correct.**
 - Listed on the Indian stock exchange with minimum prescribed public shareholding under SEBI regulations **Hence option 3 is correct.**
 - An average annual turnover of more than Rs. 25,000 crores during the last 3 years.
 - An average annual net worth of more than Rs. 15,000 crores during the last 3 years.
 - An average annual net profit after tax of more than Rs. 5,000 crores during the last 3 years. **Hence option 2 is not correct.**
 - Should have significant global presence/international operations.

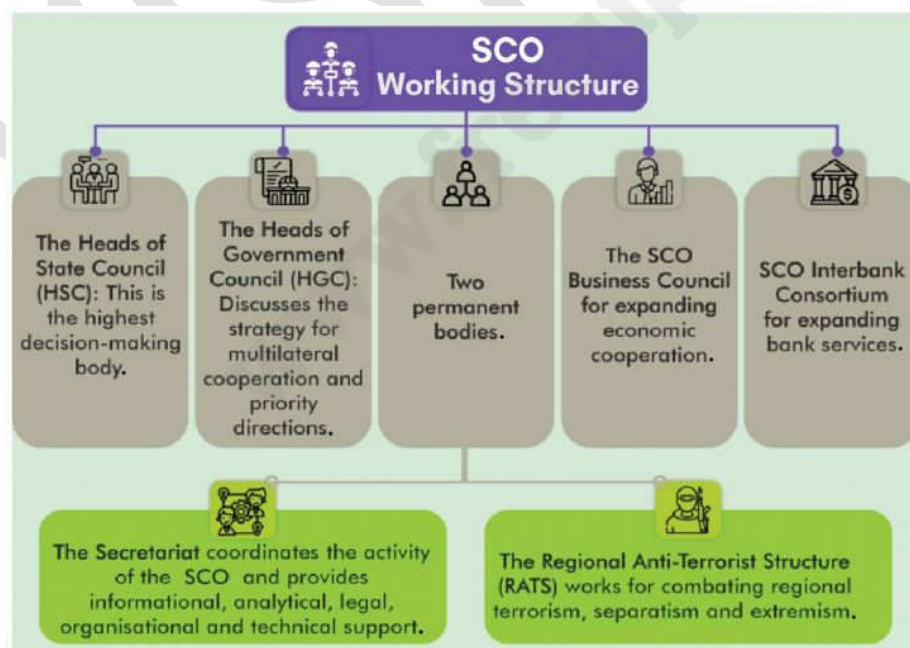
Q 30.C

- Recently, India hosted a meeting of Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS) as India assumed its role as Chairperson of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation -RATS mechanism.
- **About Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)**
 - **It is a permanent intergovernmental international organization, founded in 2001 in Shanghai (China) in 2001 by Kazakhstan, China, Kyrgyz Republic, Russia, Tajikistan, and Uzbekistan. Hence statement 1 is correct.**

- In June 2017, India and Pakistan were granted the status of a full member of SCO. SCO counts four observer states, namely the Islamic Republic of Afghanistan, the Republic of Belarus, the Islamic Republic of Iran, and Mongolia.
- Members of SCO



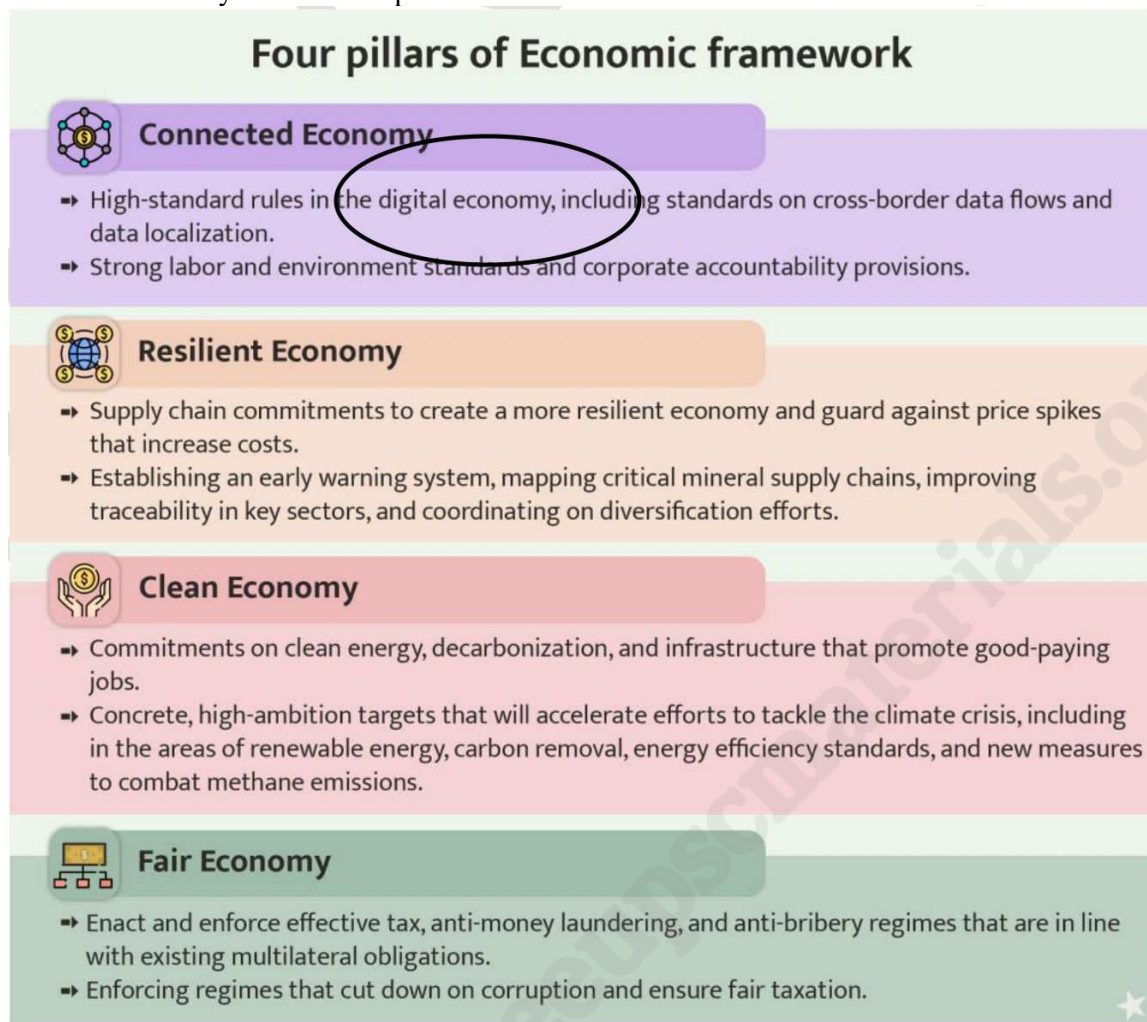
- Hence statement 3 is not correct.
- SCO's main goals are:
 - Promoting their effective cooperation in politics, trade, the economy, research, technology, and culture, as well as in education, energy, transport, tourism, environmental protection, and other areas.
 - Making joint efforts to maintain and ensure peace, security, and stability in the region
 - Moving towards the establishment of a democratic, fair and rational new international political and economic order.
- **Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS)**
 - The Agreement on RATS as a permanent SCO body was signed in 2002. **RATS is a permanent organ of SCO and it has been a coordinating center for combating terrorism, separatism and extremism at the regional and global levels. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
 - RATS platform provides a mechanism for interaction for ensuring the security of the SCO member states from transnational crimes associated with terrorism, such as illegal migration and trafficking of drugs, weapons, explosives, etc. RATS also maintains a database of terrorists and terror organizations from across its member countries.



- SCO has been an observer in the UN General Assembly since 2005. Hence statement 4 is correct.

Q 31.A

- Recently, India has agreed to be a part of the Indo-Pacific Economic Framework for Prosperity (IPEF), a US led economic grouping comprising 14 countries.
- IPEF is a U.S.-led framework for participating countries to solidify their relationships and engage in crucial economic and trade matters that concern the region, such as building resilient supply chains battered by the pandemic. It is not a free trade agreement.
- **Member states: US, Australia, Brunei, India, Indonesia, Japan, Republic of Korea, Malaysia, New Zealand, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, Fiji, and Vietnam. Together, these countries account for 40% of the global GDP. Hence statement 1 is correct and statement 2 is not correct.**
- Additionally, the framework would be open to other countries willing to join in the future. The economic framework broadly rests on four pillars:



- Countries are free to join (or not join) initiatives under any of the stipulated pillars but are expected to adhere to all commitments once they enroll.
- **IPEF is more about standard-setting and facilitating trade and will not involve more market access for its members. Nor will it negotiate lower tariffs. Hence statement 3 is not correct.**

Q 32.D

- Police reforms has been on the agenda of Governments almost since independence. Various committees and commissions set by the government to recommend suggestions on police reforms have been as follows:
 - The National Police Commission (1978-82)
 - Ribero Committee (1998). **Hence option 1 is correct.**
 - The Padmanabhaiah Committee on restructuring of Police (2000). **Hence option 4 is correct.**
 - The Malimath Committee on reforms in Criminal Justice System (2002-03). It recommended for the enactment of a new Police Act, setting up a central Law enforcement agency to take care of federal crimes, and separation of the investigation wing from the law and order wing in the police stations **Hence option 2 is correct.**
- **The Punchhi Commission was constituted by the Government of India in 2007 as a Commission on Centre-State relations. Hence option 3 is not correct.**

Q 33.D

- **The Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs)** are electronic voting machines that provide the voter with a button for each choice and it is linked by a cable to an electronic ballot box. It comprises **2 units – a control unit and a balloting unit**– which are connected by a 5-meter cable. The design and application of EVMs in the elections are considered a significant achievement in **global democracy**.
- It runs on a **power pack (Battery)** and **does not need electricity** making them more portable and suited to rural areas with regular electricity shortages. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**
- **First-time use of EVMs occurred** in a by-election for the Legislative Assembly of Kerala in May 1982. **Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**
- **According to the Election Commission of India order**, in any election being held after May 1, 2015, the Ballot papers and EVMs will carry the picture of the candidate with his or her **name and party symbol (not educational qualifications)** to avoid confusion among the electorates in constituencies where the namesakes are contesting. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**

Q 34.B

- **Recently, India jumped one position to 7th among the top recipients of foreign direct investment (FDI) in the calendar year (2021) despite FDI inflows into the country declining, according to the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD), World Investment Report.**
- The United Nations Conference on Trade and Development was established in 1964 as an intergovernmental organization intended to promote the interests of developing states in world trade. UNCTAD is part of the United Nations Secretariat dealing with trade, investment, and development issues. Its headquarters are located in Geneva, Switzerland.
- **The major reports/publications published by UNCTAD are**
 - **Trade and Development Report**
 - **World Investment Report**
 - The Least Developed Countries Report
 - Digital Economy Report
 - The Trade and Environment Review
- As per the latest World Investment Report, FDI inflows to India declined to \$45 billion in 2021 from \$64 billion in the preceding year. While the United States (\$367 billion) remained the top recipient of FDI, China (\$181 billion) and Hong Kong (\$141 billion) also retained second and third position respectively.
- UNCTAD also supports the implementation of Financing for Development, as mandated by the global community in the 2015 Addis Ababa Agenda, together with four other major institutional stakeholders: the World Bank, the International Monetary Fund, the World Trade Organization, and the United Nations Development Programme.
 - The **ECOSOC Forum on Financing for Development follow-up (FfD Forum)** is an intergovernmental process with universal participation mandated to review the Addis Ababa Action Agenda and other financings for development outcomes and the means of implementation of the SDGs.
- The **Global Competitiveness Report (GCR)** is a yearly report published by the **World Economic Forum**. The report "assesses the ability of countries to provide high levels of prosperity to their citizens". This in turn depends on how productively a country uses available resources.
- **Hence option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 35.B

- Recently, Saavira Kambada Basadi hosted the events for the International Day of Yoga.
- **Saavira Kambada Basadi (Thousand Pillars temple)** is the most prominent of the 18 Jain temples in Moodabidiri town, **Karnataka. Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- The finest of these is the 15th-century Chandranatha Basadi, also known as the **Thousand Pillars Basadi**. The uniqueness of this basadi, is that **no two pillars are identical**. Official name is Tribhuvana Thilaka Chudamani temple. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- **Jain tirthankara Chandraprabha** is the main deity in the thousand pillars temple. **Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**
- Moodabidri is known as the "Jain Varanasi" of South India. The basadis or Jain temples are found all over Dakshina Kannada district but the basadis here have greater significance and are considered as most ornate. Along with Venur and Dharmastala Moodabidri is one of the main centres of Jain pilgrimage in Dakshina Kannada.

Q 36.C

- The Central Information Commission was established by the Central Government in 2005. It was constituted through an Official Gazette Notification under the provisions of **the Right to Information Act (2005)**.
 - The Commission falls under Department of Personal and Training. **Hence option (c) is the correct answer.**
- The Central Information Commission is a high-powered independent body which inter alia looks into the complaints made to it and decide the appeals. It entertains complaints and appeals pertaining to offices, financial institutions, public sector undertakings, etc., under the Central Government and the Union Territories.
- The Commission consists of a Chief Information Commissioner and not more than ten Information Commissioners.
 - They are appointed by the President on the recommendation of a committee consisting of the Prime Minister as Chairperson, the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha and a Union Cabinet Minister nominated by the Prime Minister.
 - They should be persons of eminence in public life with wide knowledge and experience in law, science and technology, social service, management, journalism, mass media or administration and governance.
 - **They should not be a Member of Parliament or Member of the Legislature of any State or Union Territory.**
 - **They should not hold any other office of profit or connected with any political party or carrying on any business or pursuing any profession.**
- The Chief Information Commissioner and an Information Commissioner hold office for such term as prescribed by the Central Government or until they attain the age of 65 years, whichever is earlier. They are not eligible for reappointment.
- As per The Right to Information (Amendment) Act, 2019, the salary, allowances and other service conditions of the Chief Information Commissioner and an Information Commissioner **shall be such as prescribed by the Central Government**. But, they cannot be varied to his disadvantage during service.

Q 37.D

- **Online dispute resolution (ODR) is the resolution of disputes, particularly small- and medium-value cases, using digital technology and techniques of ADR, such as arbitration, conciliation and mediation. It refers to the process of using technology for dispute avoidance, containment and resolution outside the traditional court system.**
- As a dispute resolution avenue it can be provided both as an extension of the public court system and outside of it. Various ODR services available in India are as follows:
 - **SAMADHAN portal** was launched by the Ministry of Micro Small and Medium Enterprises to address disputes due to delayed payments. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
 - **e- Lok Adalat** is a virtual form of Lok Adalat under Article 39A of the Constitution. Chhattisgarh became the first state in July 2020 to conduct Virtual Lok Adalat for conciliation services. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**
 - **RBI released an ODR policy for digital payments**, wherein it had announced the introduction of Online Dispute Resolution (ODR) system for resolving customer disputes and grievances pertaining to digital payments, using a system-driven and rule-based mechanism with zero or minimal manual intervention. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
 - **Another aspect that makes India ODR ready is its legislative preparedness.** Though in a piecemeal fashion, there are numerous support legislations which provide legislative backing for the ADR aspect of ODR (such as the Arbitration and Conciliation Act, 1996 or the Code of Civil Procedure, 1908) as well as the technology aspect of ODR (such as the Indian Evidence Act, 1972 and the information and Technology Act, 2000). Further, India has also brought into force the United Nations Convention on International Settlement Agreements Resulting from Mediation, 2018.

Q 38.B

- Previously, the grievance redressal mechanism of the Income Tax Department was very cumbersome. The process to file a complaint used to move from helpline centres to websites to file online complaints. In the year 2016, the Income Tax Department changed this grueling process. **In place of this, the Income Tax Department comes up with a paperless process to address all the grievances of Income Taxpayers at a single place. The name of the system is e-Nivaran. It is a joint initiative by the Finance Ministry and the Income Tax Department.** The system is a merger of both offline and online complaints and becomes one central complaint resolution system. **Hence pair 1 is correctly matched.**

- The Centralized **Public Grievance Redress and Monitoring System (CPGRAMS)** is an online platform available to the citizens 24x7 to lodge their grievances to the public authorities on any subject related to service delivery. It is a single portal connected to all the Ministries/Departments of Government of India and States. Every Ministry and states have role-based access to this system. GRAMS also provides an appealing facility to the citizens if they are not satisfied with the resolution by the Grievance Officer. After the closure of the grievance, if the complainant is not satisfied with the resolution, he/she can provide feedback. If the rating is 'Poor' the option to file an appeal is enabled. **Hence pair 3 is correctly matched.**
- **PRAGATI** is a unique integrated and interactive platform through which the Hon'ble Prime Minister oversees the implementation of various government schemes, grievances, state and central related projects & programmes by directly interacting with all stakeholders through Videoconferencing on a single platform. PRAGATI is aimed for a culture of Pro-Active Governance through online video conferencing & meetings and Timely Implementation of projects and schemes. It is also a robust system for bringing e-transparency and e-accountability with real-time presence and exchange among the key stakeholders. **Hence pair 2 is correctly matched.**

Q 39.C

- Delimitation literally means the act or process of fixing limits or boundaries of territorial constituencies in a country or a province having a legislative body.
- The job of delimitation is assigned to a high-power body. Such a body is known as **Delimitation Commission or a Boundary Commission**. It is appointed by the **President of India** and works in collaboration with the Election Commission of India. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- Composition of Delimitation Commission:
 - Retired Supreme Court judge as Chairperson,
 - Chief Election Commissioner or an Election Commissioner nominated by the Chief Election Commissioner, ex officio
 - Respective State Election Commissioners
- The Delimitation Commission in India is a **high power body whose orders have the force of law and cannot be called in question before any court**. These orders come into force on a date to be specified by the President of India in this behalf. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- In India, such Delimitation Commissions have been **constituted 4 times (not after every decadal census)** – in **1952** under the Delimitation Commission Act, 1952, in **1963** under Delimitation Commission Act, 1962, in **1973** under Delimitation Act, 1972, and in **2002** under Delimitation Act, 2002. **Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**

Q 40.A

- The **Governance Knowledge Centre (GKC) Portal** aims to assist civil servants to seek practical and implementable solutions to the day-to-day challenges they face. It serves as a platform for collaborative knowledge exchange for the improvement of governance. It also offers a widespread and reputed lot of governance knowledge that civil society can utilize to understand the nuances of civil service practices and reforms. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- The GKC encompasses a web-based digital repository put together by a support team comprising domain experts, resource persons, analysts along with technical professionals who continuously ensure dynamic updation of Knowledge Resources and Case Studies relevant to the profile of users visiting the repository. The Digital Repository is envisaged as a tool to enable capturing, organizing, and storing for easy retrieval of digital contents with respect to the various selected case studies of "Good Governance Practices" in India and abroad.
- The **Department of Administrative Reforms & Public Grievances (DARPG), Government of India** as part of its mandate to document and disseminate good-governance initiatives launched a Web Portal, namely, **Governance Knowledge Centre (GKC) in 2005**. From 2005 to 2009, the designing and maintenance of the portal, and the creation and uploading of the content, were being done through outsourced agencies. On behalf of DARPG, OneWorld relaunched the portal and managed it till 2013. Since then, **DARPG has been maintaining the portal on its own. Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 41.B

- A State Public Service Commission consists of a chairman and other members **appointed by the governor** of the state. Although the chairman and members of a SPSC are appointed by the governor, **they can be removed only by the president** (and not by the governor). **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- The Constitution does not specify the strength of the Commission but has left the matter to the discretion of the Governor. Further, no qualifications are prescribed for the commission's membership except that

one-half of the members of the commission should be such persons who have held office for at least ten years either under the government of India or under the Government of a state.

- The Constitution also authorises the governor to determine the conditions of service of the chairman and members of the Commission.
- The chairman and members of the Commission hold office for a term of six years or until they attain the age of 62 years, whichever is earlier (in the case of UPSC, the age limit is 65 years). However, they can relinquish their offices at any time by addressing their resignation to the governor.
- **The role of SPSC is not only limited, but also recommendations made by it are only of advisory nature and hence, not binding on the government.** It is up to the state government to accept or reject that advice. The only safeguard is the answerability of the government to the state legislature for departing from the recommendation of the Commission. Further, the government can also make rules which regulate the scope of the advisory functions of SPSC. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- **The chairman of a SPSC (on ceasing to hold office) is eligible for appointment as the chairman or a member of the UPSC or as the chairman of any other SPSC, but not for any other employment under the Government of India or a state. Hence statement 3 is not correct.**
- A member of a SPSC (on ceasing to hold office) is eligible for appointment as the chairman or a member of the UPSC, or as the chairman of that SPSC or any other SPSC, but not for any other employment under the Government of India or a state.
- The chairman or a member of a SPSC is (after having completed his first term) not eligible for reappointment to that office (that is, not eligible for second term).

Q 42.C

- Article 324 of the Constitution has made the following provisions with regard to the composition of election commission:
 - The Election Commission shall consist of the chief election commissioner and such number of other election commissioners, if any, as the president may from time to time fix.
 - The appointment of the chief election commissioner and other election commissioners shall be made by the President.
 - When any other election commissioner is so appointed, the chief election commissioner shall act as the chairman of the election commission.
 - The president may also appoint after consultation with the election commission such regional commissioners as he may consider necessary to assist the election commission.
 - The conditions of service and tenure of office of the election commissioners and the regional commissioners shall be determined by the president.
- The chief election commissioner is provided with the security of tenure.
- **The Chief Election Commissioner can be removed from office only through impeachment by Parliament.** He cannot be removed from his office except in same manner and on the same grounds as a judge of the Supreme Court. In other words, he can be removed by the president on the basis of a resolution passed to that effect by both the Houses of Parliament with special majority, either on the ground of proved misbehaviour or incapacity. Thus, he does not hold his office till the pleasure of the president, though he is appointed by him. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- The service conditions of the chief election commissioner cannot be varied to his disadvantage after his appointment.
- Any other election commissioner or a regional commissioner cannot be removed from office except on the recommendation of the chief election commissioner.
- Though the constitution has sought to safeguard and ensure the independence and impartiality of the Election Commission, some flaws can be noted, viz.,
 - The Constitution has not prescribed the qualifications (legal, educational, administrative or judicial) of the members of the Election Commission.
 - The Constitution has not specified the term of the members of the Election Commission.
 - **The Constitution has not debarred the retiring election commissioners from any further appointment by the government. Hence statement 3 is not correct.**
- At the state level, the Election Commission is assisted by the chief electoral officer who is appointed by the chief election commissioner in consultation with the state government. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**

Q 43.C

- **The Public Financial Management System (PFMS) is a web-based online software application developed and implemented by the Controller General of Accounts (CGA), Department of Expenditure, Ministry of Finance, Government of India. Hence statement 1 is not correct.**

- PFMS started in 2009 with the objective of tracking funds released under all Plan schemes of the government of India, and real-time reporting of expenditure at all levels of Programme implementation. Subsequently, the scope was enlarged to cover direct payment to beneficiaries under all schemes.
- **The primary function of PFMS today** is to facilitate sound Public Financial Management System for the Government of India **by establishing an efficient fund flow system as well as a payment cum accounting network.** PFMS provides various stakeholders with a real-time, reliable and meaningful management information system and an effective decision support system, as part of the Digital India initiative of the Government of India. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- PFMS has established an interface with the treasury systems of all the 28 States and the 2 Union Territories with Legislatures. This facilitates the exchange of data regarding budget, allocation and expenditure against the central transfer of funds for Centrally Sponsored Schemes of the Government of India.
- **The mandate given to PFMS by Cabinet** is to provide financial management platform for all plan schemes, a database of all recipient agencies, integration with core banking solutions of banks handling plan funds, integration with State Treasuries and efficient and effective tracking of fund flow to the lowest level of implementation for plan scheme of the Government.
- **As the backbone of the payment system of the Government of India, PFMS is integrated with the Core Banking system in the country, and hence, has the unique capability to first validate the account before pushing online payments to almost every beneficiary/vendor. Hence statement 3 is correct.**
 - At present, PFMS has an interface with the **Core Banking System (CBS) of over 300 Banks, including all Public Sector Banks, all Regional Rural Banks, major private sector banks, Reserve Bank of India, India post and Cooperative Banks.** With time, the integration has to become **universal, i.e. interface is to be established with all the Banks operating in India.** Interface with the National Payments Corporation of India (NPCI) has also been developed that facilitates validation for Aadhaar-linked payments.
- Every Department/Ministry of Government of India transfers funds electronically to beneficiaries through PFMS. Further, State Governments and the Implementing Agencies transfer the cash components to beneficiaries through PFMS.
 - **To facilitate the above, PFMS has an interface with over fifty Beneficiary management applications/systems of different Ministries and Departments, such as PM-KISAN, NSAP, MNREGASoft, MCTS, AwasSoft and Kanyashree.**

Q 44.B

- The **Finance Bill of 2017** amended **Section 182 of the Companies Act of 2013** to remove the requirement for declaring disaggregated donations to political parties.
- Earlier, only profit-making domestic companies could contribute to political parties; **now loss-making companies can make contributions too. Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- Further, the **limit of 7.5% for corporate donations** to political parties has been **removed.** With this amendment corporations are free to donate any amount of money and are not liable to declare the recipient of their donations. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Q 45.A

- **The 97th Constitutional Amendment Act of 2011 gave a constitutional status and protection to co-operative societies.** In this context, it made the following three changes in the constitution:
 - It made the right to form co-operative societies a **fundamental right (Article 19).** In Part III of the Constitution, in Article 19, in clause (1), in sub-clause (c), the words **“co-operative societies”** were **inserted.**
 - It included a **new Directive Principle of State Policy on promotion of co-operative societies (Article 43-B).** In Part IV of the Constitution, a new Article 43-B was inserted, which says: “The state shall endeavour to promote voluntary formation, autonomous functioning, democratic control and professional management of cooperative societies”.
 - It added a **new Part IX-B in the Constitution which is entitled “The Co-operative Societies” (Articles 243-ZH to 243-ZT).**
- The Act provides for:
 - incorporation, regulation and winding up of cooperative societies
 - **specifying the maximum number of directors of a co-operative society** to be not exceeding twenty-one members;
 - a **fixed term of five years from the date of election** in respect of the elected members of the board and its office bearers; and an authority or body for the conduct of elections to a cooperative society; a

maximum time limit of six months during which board of directors of a co-operative society could be kept under supersession or suspension;

- **reservation of one seat for the Scheduled Castes or the Scheduled Tribes** and two seats for women on the board of every cooperative society, which have individuals as members from such categories.
- **Recently, Supreme Court struck down parts of the Act** which shrunk the **exclusive authority of States** over its co-operative societies as the act was passed by the Parliament without getting them ratified by State legislatures as required by the Constitution.
 - The Court observed that the Act significantly impacted 'state legislatures' "**exclusive legislative power**" over its co-operative sector under **Entry 32 of the State List to over the co-operative sector**. The court pointed out how Article 243ZI makes it clear that a State may only make law on the incorporation, regulation and winding up of a co-operative society subject to the provisions of Part IXB of the 97th Constitutional Amendment.
 - However, the court **did not strike down** the portions of Part IXB of the Amendment **concerning 'Multi State Cooperative Societies'** due to the lack of ratification.

Q 46.C

- **The Constitution does not specify the official language of different states. In this regard, it makes the following provisions:**
- **The legislature of a state may adopt any one or more of the languages** in use in the state or Hindi as **the official language of that state**. Until that is done, English is to continue as official language of that state. **Hence statements 1 and 2 are not correct.**
- Under this provision, most of the states have adopted the major regional language as their official language. For example, Andhra Pradesh has adopted Telugu, Kerala– Malayalam, Assam–Assamese, West Bengal– Bengali, Odisha–Odia. The nine northern states of Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Bihar, Jharkhand, Haryana and Rajasthan have adopted Hindi. Gujarat has adopted Hindi in addition to Gujarati. Similarly, Goa has adopted Marathi in addition to Konkani. Jammu and Kashmir has adopted Urdu (and not Kashmiri).
- On the other hand, certain north-eastern States like Meghalaya, Arunachal Pradesh and Nagaland have adopted English. **Notably, the choice of the state is not limited to the languages enumerated in the Eighth Schedule of the Constitution. Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- For the time being, the official language of the Union (i.e., English) would remain the link language for communications between the Union and the states or between various states. But, two or more states are free to agree to use Hindi (instead of English) for communication between themselves. Rajasthan, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and Bihar are some of the states that have entered into such agreements.
- The Official Languages Act (1963) lays down that English should be used for purposes of communication between the Union and the non-Hindi states (that is, the states that have not adopted Hindi as their official language). Further, where Hindi is used for communication between a Hindi and a nonHindi state, such communication in Hindi should be accompanied by an English translation.
- When the **President (on a demand being made)** is satisfied that a substantial proportion of the population of a state desire the use of any language spoken by them to be recognised by that state, then he may **direct that such language shall also be officially recognised in that state**. This provision aims at protecting the linguistic interests of minorities in the states.

Q 47.A

- The Right to Information Act of 2005 provides for the creation of not only the Central Information Commission but also a State Information Commission at the state level.
- The Commission consists of a State Chief Information Commissioner and not more than ten State Information Commissioners.
 - They are **appointed by the Governor** on the recommendation of a committee consisting of the Chief Minister as Chairperson, the Leader of Opposition in the Legislative Assembly and a State Cabinet Minister nominated by the Chief Minister.
 - They should not be a Member of Parliament or Member of the Legislature of any State or Union Territory.
 - They should not hold any other office of profit or connected with any political party or carrying on any business or pursuing any profession.
- The State Chief Information Commissioner and a State Information Commissioner hold office for such term as prescribed by the Central Government or until they attain the age of 65 years, whichever is earlier. They are not eligible for reappointment.

- The salary, allowances and other service conditions of the State Chief Information Commissioner and a State Information Commissioner **shall be such as prescribed by the Central Government**. But, they cannot be varied to his disadvantage during service. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- **The Governor can remove** the State Chief Information Commissioner or any State Information Commissioner from the office under the following circumstances:
 - if he is adjudged an insolvent; or
 - if he has been convicted of an offence which (in the opinion of the Governor) involves a moral turpitude; or
 - if he engages during his term of office in any paid employment outside the duties of his office; or
 - if he is (in the opinion of the Governor) unfit to continue in office due to infirmity of mind or body; or
 - if he has acquired such financial or other interest as is likely to affect prejudicially his official functions.
 - **Hence statement 3 is not correct.**
- In addition to these, the Governor can also remove the State Chief Information Commissioner or any State Information Commissioner on the ground of proved misbehaviour or incapacity. However, in these cases, the Governor has to refer the matter to the Supreme Court for an enquiry. If the Supreme Court, after the enquiry, upholds the cause of removal and advises so, then the Governor can remove him.
- **The Commission can order inquiry into any matter if there are reasonable grounds (suo-moto power).** **Hence statement 1 is correct.**

Q 48.C

- The Protection of Human Rights Act of 1993 provides for the creation of not only the National Human Rights Commission but also a State Human Rights Commission at the state level.
- The State Human Rights Commission is a multi-member body consisting of a chairperson and two members.
- The chairperson and members are appointed by the Governor on the recommendations of a committee consisting of the chief minister as its head, the speaker of the Legislative Assembly, the state home minister and the leader of the opposition in the Legislative Assembly. In the case of a state having Legislative Council, the chairman of the Council and the leader of the opposition in the Council would also be the members of the committee. Further, a sitting judge of a High Court or a sitting District Judge can be appointed only after consultation with the Chief Justice of the High Court of the concerned state.
- Although the chairperson and members of a State Human Rights Commission are appointed by the governor, **they can be removed only by the President (and not by the governor).** **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
 - The President can remove them on the same grounds and in the same manner as he can remove the chairperson or a member of the National Human Rights Commission.
- Term of office of Chairperson and Members of the State Commission-
 - A person appointed as Chairperson shall hold office for a term of **three years** from the date on which he enters upon his office or until he attains the **age of seventy years**, whichever is earlier and shall be eligible for re-appointment.
 - A person appointed as a Member shall hold office for a term of **three years** from the date on which he enters upon his office and shall be eligible for re-appointment. Provided that no Member shall hold office after he has attained the age of **seventy years**.
 - On ceasing to hold office, a Chairperson or a Member shall be ineligible for further employment under the Government of a State or under the Government of India. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**

Q 49.B

- The Parliament enacted the Official Languages Act in 1963. The act provides for the continued use of English (even after 1965), in addition to Hindi, for all official purposes of the Union and also for the transaction of business in Parliament. **Notably, this act enables the use of English indefinitely (without any time-limit).** Further, this act was amended in 1967 to make the use of English, in addition to Hindi, compulsory in certain cases:
 - These include: (a) resolutions, general orders, rules, notifications, administrative or other reports or press communications issued by the Central government; (b) administrative and other reports and official papers laid before Parliament; and (c) **contracts and agreements executed, licences, permits, notices, etc., issued by the Central government or by a corporation or a company owned by the Central government.** Hence, statements 1 and 3 are correct.
- **The Official Languages Act (1963) provided for the setting up of a Committee of Parliament on Official Language to review the progress made in the use of Hindi for the official purpose of the**

Union. Under the Act, this Committee was to be constituted after ten years of the promulgation of the Act (i.e., 26th January, 1965). Accordingly, this Committee was set up in 1976. This Committee comprises of 30 members of Parliament, 20 from Lok Sabha and 10 from Rajya Sabha. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 50.A

- Recently, in the ongoing **Ukraine-Russian conflict**, **Ukrainian forces have taken control of Snake Island in the Black Sea**, which was occupied by Russia very early in the war.
- **Snake or Serpent Island, called Zmiinyi in Ukrainian**, is a rocky outcrop that extends less than 700 metres from end to end, and is often described as being “X-shaped”. It is located 35 km from the coast, **to the east of the mouth of the Danube and roughly southwest of Odessa**. The island has been known since ancient times. Tales about it go back to the mythological Trojan war.
- The island is also close to the coast of Romania, with which Ukraine has had a dispute — and which was settled in 2009 by the International Court of Justice, which drew a new maritime border between the two countries.
- **Hence option (a) is the correct answer.**

Q 51.B

- Article 280 of the Constitution of India provides for a Finance Commission as a quasi judicial body. It is constituted by the president of India every fifth year or at such earlier time as he considers necessary.
- The Finance Commission consists of a chairman and four other members to be **appointed by the President. They hold office for such period as specified by the President in his order. They are eligible for reappointment.**
- The Constitution authorises the Parliament to determine the qualifications of members of the commission and the manner in which they should be selected.
- **The chairman should be a person having experience in public affairs** and the four other members should be selected from amongst the following:
 - A judge of high court or one qualified to be appointed as one.
 - A person who has specialised knowledge of finance and accounts of the government.
 - A person who has wide experience in financial matters and in administration.
 - A person who has special knowledge of economics.
 - **Hence statement 3 is not correct.**
- The commission submits its report to the president. He lays it before both the Houses of Parliament along with an explanatory memorandum as to the action taken on its recommendations.
- **The recommendations made by the Finance Commission are only of advisory nature and hence, not binding on the government.** It is up to the Union government to implement its recommendations on granting money to the states. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- The Commission can determine their procedure and in the performance of their functions can **have all the powers of a civil court under the Code of Civil Procedure, 1908** (5 of 1908), while trying a suit in respect of the following matters, namely:
 - summoning and enforcing the attendance of witnesses;
 - requiring the production of any document;
 - requisitioning any public record from any court or office.
 - **Hence statement 1 is correct.**

Q 52.C

- In February, the **Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS)** announced severe sanctions on **Mali**, seeking to discourage further coups, but this did not deter the coup in Burkina Faso. However under pressure from the ECOWAS group, Mali junta adopts transition to democratic rule from March 2022 (time line of 24 months).
- Established on May 28 **1975 via the treaty of Lagos**, ECOWAS is a 15-member regional group with a mandate of promoting economic integration in all fields of activity of the constituting countries. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The **Horn of Africa**, also known as the **Somali Peninsula**, is a large peninsula in East Africa. Its countries are **not members of ECOWAS**. The members of ECOWAS include Benin, Burkina Faso, Cape Verde, Cote d’Ivoire, The Gambia, Ghana, Guinea, Guinea Bissau, Liberia, Mali, Niger, Nigeria, Sierra Leone, Senegal and Togo. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**

- Considered one of the pillars of the African Economic Community, ECOWAS was set up to foster the ideal of collective self-sufficiency for its member states. As a trading union, it is also meant to create a **single, large trading bloc** through economic cooperation. **Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

Q 53.C

- The Constitution (Article 76) has provided for the office of the Attorney General for India. **He is the highest law officer in the country. Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- The Attorney General (AG) is appointed by the president. He must be a person who is qualified to be appointed a judge of the Supreme Court. In other words, **he must be a citizen of India and he must have been a judge of some high court for five years** or an advocate of some high court for ten years or an eminent jurist, in the opinion of the president.
- **The term of office of the AG is not fixed by the Constitution.** Further, the Constitution does not contain the procedure and grounds for his removal. He holds office during the pleasure of the president. This means that he may be removed by the president at any time. He may also quit his office by submitting his resignation to the president. Conventionally, he resigns when the government (council of ministers) resigns or is replaced, as he is appointed on its advice. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- **The remuneration of the AG is not fixed by the Constitution. He receives such remuneration as the president may determine.**
- The Table of Precedence is related to the rank and order of the officials of the Union and State Governments. Attorney General of India along with Cabinet Secretary and Lieutenant Governors within their respective Union Territories are ranked at 11th position, whereas, Cabinet Ministers of the Union along with the Chief Ministers of States within their respective States, Vice Chairperson NITI Aayog, Former Prime Ministers and Leaders of Opposition in Rajya Sabha and Lok Sabha are ranked at 7th. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 54.A

- A **star campaigner** is a celebrity vote seeker in an election for a party. This person can be anyone, a politician or even a film star.
- **Section 77 of the Representation of the People Act, 1951**, which relates to a candidate's election expenditure, leaves it to the political parties itself to decide who their "leaders" are and allows every party to submit a list of such 'star campaigners' to the election authorities. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- Expenditure incurred on electioneering by the star campaigner is **not added to a candidate's poll expenditure** giving him/her more scope for expenditure. However, for an individual candidate to get relief from campaign expenditure, the star campaigner has to limit oneself to general campaigning for the party. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**
- The Model Code of Conduct guidelines say when a **prime minister or a former prime minister is a star campaigner**, the expenditure incurred on **security** including on the bullet-proof vehicles will be **borne by the government** and will not be added to the election expenses of the party or the individual candidate. **Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

Q 55.A

- **Government e-Marketplace (GeM) has been envisaged as the National Procurement Portal of India by the government. It is a one-stop portal to facilitate online procurement of common use Goods & Services required by various Government Departments / Organizations / PSUs. GeM aims to enhance transparency, efficiency and speed in public procurement.**
- GeM is a **completely paperless, cashless and system-driven e-marketplace** that enables procurement of common-use goods and services with minimal human interface. **It provides the tools of e-bidding, reverse e-auction and demand aggregation to facilitate the government users to achieve the best value for their money. Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- The "Seller(s)" on GeM will be the private OEMs (Original Equipment Manufacturers) and/or their authorized channel partner(s)/ resellers (having any general authorization/dealership of the OEM to sell their product in the open market) and e- Marketplaces.
- **All Central government and State Government Ministries/Departments including its attached/ subordinate offices, Central and State autonomous bodies, Central and State Public Sector Units and local bodies, etc. are authorized buyers to make procurement through the GeM portal. To this date procurement facilities for private buyers (businesses, startups), individual customers and retail consumers were not allowed on the GeM platform. Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

- GeM 3.0 and 4.0 has a powerful search engine and price comparison tool using third-party sites which are real-time and multisource. Also, it provided the facility for seller's and buyer's interaction for offering scope for improvement and a better understanding of the market.

Q 56.B

- An **opinion poll** is a **pre-election survey** to gather voters' views on a range of election-related issues. An **exit poll**, on the other hand, is conducted immediately **after people have voted**, and assesses the support for political parties and their candidates. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
- **Section 126A of the Representation of the People's Act, 1951 (RPA, 1951), puts a ban on exit polls** from the period between the commencements of the poll until half an hour after the closing of the final phase of the poll. However, there are **no similar restrictions placed on opinion polls under RPA**. Election Commission has held consultations with political parties to revive its demand to restrict pre-election opinion polls as well from the date of notification of elections until the end of polling. But no action has been taken so far. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Q 57.A

- Recently, **Fostering Effective Energy Transition Report** was released by **World Economic Forum**. **Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.**
- Report uses 'Energy Transition Index' to benchmark countries' energy transition progress annually on the three dimensions of energy triangle and the enabling dimensions for transition. Energy transition refers to shift from fossil-based systems of energy production and consumption to renewable energy sources like wind and solar.
- **Key Findings of the report**
 - Energy transition not keeping pace with growing climate urgency with challenges compounded by risks to energy security, sustainability, and affordable access.
 - Lack of access to an affordable energy supply has emerged as a key threat to a just transition.
 - Industrial activity generates more than 30% of anthropogenic emissions with 5 heavy industries representing 80% of industrial emissions.
 - Dual diversification (of supply source and supply mix) is key to strengthening countries' energy security.
- Other Energy Transition Reports/Indexes:
 - **World energy transitions outlook 2022** was released by the **International Renewable Energy Agency (IRENA)** at the Berlin Energy Transition Dialogue. The Outlook sets out priority areas and actions based on available technologies that must be realised by 2030 to achieve net zero emissions by mid-century, a statement by IRENA said.
 - **The Global Energy Transition Index (ETI)** is published by **World Economic Forum (WEF)** to quantify the global change to renewable energy. It provides a numerical value for how well a country is doing in their transition to renewable energy and also helps in developing energy transition roadmaps.

Q 58.D

- **The Constitution contains the following provisions in respect of the official language of the Union:**
 - **Hindi written in Devanagari script is to be the official language of the Union. But, the form of numerals to be used for the official purposes of the Union has to be the international form of Indian numerals and not the Devanagari form of numerals.**
 - However, for a period of fifteen years from the commencement of the Constitution (i.e., from 1950 to 1965), the English language would continue to be used for all the official purposes of the Union for which it was being used before 1950. Even after fifteen years, the **Parliament may provide** for the continued use of **English language** for the specified purposes.
 - At the end of five years, and again at the end of ten years, from the commencement of the Constitution, the **president should appoint a commission** to make recommendations with regard to the **progressive use of the Hindi language, restrictions on the use of the English language** and other related issues.
 - A committee of Parliament is to be constituted to examine the recommendations of the commission and to report its views on them to the president. Accordingly, in **1955**, the president appointed an Official Language Commission under the chairmanship of **B.G. Kher**.
- The **Constitution does not specify the official language of different states**. In this regard, it makes the following provisions:
 - The **legislature of a state may adopt** any one or more of the languages in use in the state or Hindi as the official language of that state. Until that is done, English is to continue as official language of that state. **Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**

- The constitutional provisions dealing with the language of the courts and legislation are as follows:
 - **Until Parliament provides otherwise, the following are to be in the English language only:**
 - ✓ All proceedings in the Supreme Court and in every high court.
 - ✓ However, the governor of a state, with the previous consent of the president, can authorise the use of Hindi or any other official language of the state, in the proceedings in the high court of the state, but not with respect to the judgements, decrees and orders passed by it. **In other words, the judgements, decrees and orders of the high court must continue to be in English only (until Parliament otherwise provides). Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**
 - ✓ Also, the **Official Languages Act of 1963** lays down that Hindi translation of acts, ordinances, orders, regulations and bye-laws published under the authority of the president are deemed to be authoritative texts. Further, every bill introduced in the Parliament is to be accompanied by a Hindi translation. Similarly, there is to be a Hindi translation of state acts or ordinances in certain cases.

Q 59.A

- **The Model Code of Conduct (MCC)** consists of a set of guidelines expected to be abiding by the political parties, their campaigners and the candidates. The Election Commission brings the Model Code of Conduct into effect to ensure **free and fair elections**.
- The Model Code of Conduct remains in place during the elections in respect of political parties and candidates which remains in force from the date the elections are announced by the Commission till the completion of elections.
- The provisions of MCC and related instructions of the Commission issued from time to time **also apply to the content being posted on the internet, including social media websites, by candidates and political parties. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
- The **State of Kerala adopted MCC for the first time in India** during the general election to the State Legislative Assembly in February 1960. **Hence, statement 3 is not correct.**
- Though the Election Commission of India **does not have a judicial ability to penalise the violators of the Model Code of Conduct**, it generally issues show-cause notice to the violators and in some cases, bars them from the poll campaign. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Q 60.D

- Under **State Funding of elections**, the **government gives funds to political parties or candidates for contesting elections**. Its main purpose is to make it unnecessary for contestants to take money from powerful moneyed interests so that they can remain clean.
- **Indrajit Gupta Committee (1998):** It suggested that **state funding would ensure a level playing field** for poorer political parties and argued that such a move would be in the public interest. It also recommended that state funds should only be given to recognized national and State parties and funding should be given in the form of free facilities provided to these parties and their candidates.
- **Rajmanner Commission (1969)** was appointed to look into the question regarding the relationship that should subsist between the **Centre and the States in a federal set-up**.
- **The National Commission to Review the Working of the Constitution (2000)** headed by M. N. Venkatachaliah **did not endorse state funding** of elections.
- **Jaya Prakash Narayan Committee (1974)** recommended changing the **procedure of appointment of the Chief Election Commissioner**.
- **Hence, option (d) is the correct answer.**

Q 61.D

- Constitutional Authorities and other Dignitaries which may Display the Emblem on their Cars:
 - cars of Rashtrapati Bhawan, when the following dignitaries or their spouses are travelling by such vehicles:
 - ✓ **President,**
 - ✓ visiting Heads of foreign States,
 - ✓ visiting Vice-Presidents of foreign. State or dignitaries of equivalent status,
 - ✓ visiting heads of foreign Governments or dignitaries of equivalent status like Crown Prince or Princess of a foreign State,
 - ✓ the spare car following the car of the President;
 - **car of Vice-President** when he or his spouse is travelling by such vehicle;
 - cars of Raj Bhawan and Raj Niwas, if the emblem is adopted by, or incorporated in the Emblem of, that State or the Union territory, when the following dignitaries or their spouses are travelling by such vehicles within the State or the Union territory concerned:

- ✓ President,
- ✓ Vice-President,
- ✓ Governor of the State,
- ✓ Lieutenant Governor of the Union territory,
- ✓ Visiting Heads of foreign States,
- ✓ Visiting Vice-Presidents of foreign States or dignitaries of equivalent status,
- ✓ Visiting Heads of foreign Governments or dignitaries of equivalent status;
- cars and other means of transport used by the Heads of **India's Diplomatic Missions in the countries of their accreditation**;
- cars and other means of transport used by the Heads of India's Counselor posts abroad in the countries of their accreditation; cars maintained by the Protocol Division of the Ministry of External Affairs when in use for duty with the foreign dignitaries of the rank of Cabinet Ministers and above visiting India, and Ambassadors accredited to India on ceremonial occasions.
- **Authorities which may Display the Ashoka Chakra (which is Part of the Emblem) on Triangular Metal Plaques on their Cars:**
 - cars of the **Prime Minister** and Ministers of the Union, Speaker and Deputy Speaker of the Lok Sabha, Deputy Chairperson of the Rajya Sabha when travelling anywhere in India;
 - cars of **Chief Justice of India** and Judges of the Supreme Court, and Chief Justices and Judges of High Courts within their respective territories;
 - cars of Cabinet Ministers in States, Ministers of States in States, Speakers and Deputy Speakers of the State Legislative Assemblies, Chairmen and Deputy Chairmen of Councils of States, Ministers (other than Deputy Ministers) of Union territories with Legislature, and Speakers and Deputy Speakers of Legislative Assemblies in Union territories, when they are travelling within their State or Union territory, as the case may be (if the emblem is adopted by, or is incorporated in the Emblem of, the State or the Union territory).
- **Hence option (d) is the correct answer.**

Q 62.A

- **The Forests Rights Act, 2006 also called the Scheduled Tribes And Other Traditional Forest Dwellers (Recognition Of Forest Rights) Act, 2006** recognizes the rights of the forest-dwelling tribal communities and other traditional forest dwellers to forest resources, on which these communities were dependent for a variety of needs, including livelihood, habitation and other socio-cultural needs.
- The Act encompasses **Rights of Self-cultivation and Habitation which are usually regarded as Individual rights; and Community Rights such as Grazing, Fishing and access to Water bodies in forests, Habitat Rights for PVTGs**, Traditional Seasonal Resource access to Nomadic and Pastoral communities, access to biodiversity, community right to intellectual property and traditional knowledge, recognition of traditional customary rights and right to protect, regenerate or conserve or manage any community forest resource for sustainable use. **The Act considers the Gram Sabha as the initiating authority for determining the nature and extent of the individual as well as community forest rights. Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- In conjunction with the **Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Settlement Act, 2013 FRA** protects the tribal population from eviction without rehabilitation and settlement.
- The Act empowers the forest dwellers to access and use the forest resources in the manner that they were traditionally accustomed, to protect, conserve and manage forests, protect forest dwellers from unlawful evictions and also provides for basic development facilities for the community of forest dwellers to access facilities of education, health, nutrition, infrastructure etc.
- The **Ministry of Tribal Affairs (MoTA)** is the nodal ministry for the Forest Rights Act 2006. Hence statement 2 is not correct.

Q 63.B

- As per the **Companies Act, 2013**, Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO) has been established by the Government of India. **Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- It is a multi-disciplinary organization **under the Ministry of Corporate Affairs**, consisting of experts in the field of accountancy, forensic auditing, banking, law, information technology, investigation, company law, capital market and taxation, etc. for detecting and prosecuting or recommending for prosecution white-collar crimes/frauds. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**
 - **Under section 212(8) of the Companies Act, 2013**, SFIO also has powers to arrest people for the violation of the Company law. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**

- Investigation into the affairs of a company is assigned to SFIO, where Government is of the opinion that it is necessary to investigate into the affairs of a company –
 - On receipt of a report of the Registrar or inspector under section 208 of the Companies Act, 2013
 - On intimation of a special resolution passed by a company that its affairs are required to be investigated
 - In the public interest; or On request from any department of the Central Government or a State Government
- SFIO is headed by a Director as Head of Department in the rank of Joint Secretary to the Government of India. The Director is assisted by Additional Directors, Joint Directors, Deputy Directors, Senior Assistant Directors, Assistant Directors Prosecutors, and other secretarial staff.
- The Headquarter of SFIO is in New Delhi, with five Regional Offices in Mumbai, New Delhi, Chennai, Hyderabad & Kolkata.

Q 64.B

- The NITI Aayog (National Institution for Transforming India) was established as the successor to the planning commission. However, it must be noted here that the NITI Aayog, like that of the Planning Commission, was also created by an executive resolution of the Government of India (i.e., Union Cabinet). Hence, it is also neither a constitutional body nor a statutory body. In other words, it is a non-constitutional or extra-constitutional body (i.e., not created by the Constitution) and a non-statutory body (not created by an Act of the Parliament).
- The composition of the NITI Aayog is as follows:
 - **Chairperson:** The Prime Minister of India
 - **Governing Council:** It comprises the Chief Ministers of all the States, Chief Ministers of Union Territories with Legislatures (i.e., Delhi and Puducherry) and Lt. Governors of other Union Territories. **Hence option (b) is the correct answer.**
 - **Regional Councils:** These are formed to address specific issues and contingencies impacting more than one state or a region. These are formed for a specified tenure. These are convened by the Prime Minister and comprises of the Chief Ministers of States and Lt. Governors of Union Territories in the region. These are chaired by the Chairperson of the NITI Aayog or his nominee.
 - **Special Invitees:** Experts, specialists and practitioners with relevant domain knowledge as special invitees nominated by the Prime Minister.
 - **Full-time Organisational Framework: It comprises, in addition to the Prime Minister as the Chairperson:**
 - ✓ **Vice-Chairperson:** He is appointed by the Prime Minister. He enjoys the rank of a Cabinet Minister.
 - ✓ **Members:** Full-time. They enjoy the rank of a Minister of State.
 - ✓ **Part-time Members:** Maximum of 2, from leading universities, research organisations and other relevant institutions in an ex-officio capacity. Part-time members would be on a rotation.
 - ✓ **Ex-Officio Members:** Maximum of 4 members of the Union Council of Ministers to be nominated by the Prime Minister.
 - ✓ **Chief Executive Officer:** He is appointed by the Prime Minister for a fixed tenure, in the rank of Secretary to the Government of India.

Q 65.D

- **Cooperatives are a state subject**, but there are many societies such as those for sugar and milk, banks, milk unions etc whose members and areas of operation are spread across more than one state. The Multi State Cooperative Societies (MSCS) Act, 2002 was passed to govern such cooperatives. For example, most sugar mills along the districts on the Karnataka-Maharashtra border procure cane from both states. **Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- They draw their membership from both states, and they are thus registered under the MSCS Act. Their board of directors has representation from all states they operate in. **Administrative and financial control of these societies is with the central registrar, with the law making it clear that no state government official can wield any control on them. Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**
- The cooperative societies provisions shall apply to the multi-state co-operative societies subject to the modification that any reference to the “State Legislature”, “State Act” or “State Government” shall be construed as a reference to “Parliament”, “Central Act” or “Central Government” respectively.

Q 66.B

- The **National Commission to Review the Working of the Constitution** was set up by Government Resolution in **2000** under the **Chairmanship of Justice M. N. Venkatachaliah**. The Commission submitted its report in two volumes to the Government in March, 2002.
- The few of the recommendations of the commission are mentioned below:
 - **On Fundamental Rights**
 - ✓ The scope of prohibition against discrimination (under Articles 15 and 16) should be extended to include 'ethnic or social origin, political or other opinion, property or birth'.
 - ✓ The freedom of speech and expression (under Article 19) should be expanded to include explicitly 'the freedom of the press and other media, the freedom to hold opinions and to seek, receive and impart information and ideas'.
 - ✓ The following should be added as new Fundamental Rights:
 - Right against torture, cruelty and inhuman treatment or punishment.
 - **Right to compensation if a person is illegally deprived of his right to life or liberty. Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
 - Right to leave and to return to India.
 - Right to privacy and family life.
 - Right to rural wage employment for a minimum of 80 days in a year.
 - Right to access to courts and tribunals and speedy justice.
 - Right to equal justice and free legal aid⁸.
 - Right to care and assistance and protection (in case of children).
 - Right to safe drinking water, prevention of pollution, conservation of ecology and sustainable development.
 - **Sikhism, Jainism and Buddhism should be treated as religions separate from Hinduism and the provisions grouping them together (under Article 25) should be deleted. At present, the word 'Hindu' is defined to include these religions also.**
 - **On Directive Principles of State Policy**
 - ✓ The heading of Part-IV of the Constitution should be amended to read as 'Directive Principles of State Policy and Action'.
 - ✓ **A new Directive Principle on control of population should be added. Hence, statement 3 is correct.**
 - ✓ **An independent National Education Commission should be set-up every five years. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
 - ✓ An Inter-Faith Commission should be established to promote inter-religious harmony and social solidarity.
 - ✓ There must be a body of high status to review the level of implementation of the Directive Principles.
 - ✓ A strategic Plan of Action should be initiated to create a large number of employment opportunities in five years.
 - ✓ Implementation of the recommendations contained in the Report of the National Statistical Commission (2001).
 - **On Fundamental Duties**
 - ✓ Consideration should be given to the ways and means by which Fundamental Duties could be popularized and made effective.
 - ✓ The recommendations of the Justice Verma Committee on operationalisation of Fundamental Duties should be implemented at the earliest.
 - ✓ The following new fundamental duties should be included in Article 51-A:
 - **Duty to vote at elections, actively participate in the democratic process of governance and to pay taxes. Hence, statement 5 is correct.**
 - To foster a spirit of family values and responsible parenthood in the matter of education, physical and moral well-being of children.
 - Duty of industrial organizations to provide education to children of their employees.
 - **On Centre-State and Inter-State Relations**
 - ✓ A statutory body called the Inter-State Trade and Commerce Commission should be established.
 - ✓ The president should appoint the governor of a state only after consultation with the chief minister of that state.
 - ✓ **Article 356 should not be deleted, but it must be used sparingly and only as a remedy of the last resort. Hence, statement 4 is not correct.**

- ✓ Even without the state being under a proclamation of emergency, President's Rule may be continued if elections cannot be held. Article 356 should be amended to this effect.
- ✓ The State Assembly should not be dissolved before the proclamation issued under Article 356 has been laid before Parliament. Article 356 should be amended to ensure this.

Q 67.C

- The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) was set up in 1963 by a resolution of the Ministry of Home Affairs. Later, it was transferred to the **Ministry of Personnel** and now it enjoys the status of **an attached office**. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- The Special Police Establishment (which looked into vigilance cases) setup in 1941 was also merged with the CBI.
- The establishment of the CBI was recommended by the Santhanam Committee on Prevention of Corruption (1962-1964).
- **The CBI is not a statutory body. It derives its powers from the Delhi Special Police Establishment Act, 1946. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- The CBI is the main investigating agency of the Central Government. It plays an important role in the prevention of corruption and maintaining integrity in administration. It also provides assistance to the Central Vigilance Commission and Lokpal.
- The CBI is headed by a Director. He is assisted by a special director or an additional director.
- **The Central Government shall appoint the Director of CBI on the recommendation of a three-member committee consisting of the Prime Minister as Chairperson, the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha and the Chief Justice of India or Judge of the Supreme Court nominated by him. Hence statement 3 is not correct.**
- The CBI acts as the "National Central Bureau" of Interpol in India. The Interpol Wing of the CBI coordinates requests for investigation-related activities originating from Indian law enforcement agencies and the member countries of the Interpol.

Q 68.A

- **The National Programme for Civil Services Capacity Building ('NPCSCB') – "Mission Karmayogi" has been launched with the objective of enhancing governance through Civil Service Capacity Building.**
- It will enable officials to pursue anytime-anyplace-any device learning at their own convenience, using self-directed or guided learning paths, enabling continuous learning for all
- It will provide officials with access to instant guidance at the point of need, through job-specific learning resources and collaboration with officials who "have done it before"
- It will empower an official with tool to take charge of one's own professional learning journey, making officials accountable for their own career trajectory.
- **Salient Features:**
 - **Aligning work allocation of civil servants by matching their competencies to the requirements of the posts, such that transition from 'Rule based' to 'Role based' HR Management is smoothly attained. Hence statement 1 is correct.**
 - **To emphasize on 'on-site' learning to complement the 'off-site' learning. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
 - To calibrate all Civil Service positions to a Framework of Roles, Activities and Competencies (FRAC) approach and to create and deliver learning content relevant to the identified FRAC in every Government entity.
 - To make available to all civil servants, an opportunity to continuously build and strengthen their Behavioural, Functional and Domain Competencies in their self-driven and mandated learning paths.
 - **To create an ecosystem of shared training infrastructure including that of learning materials, institutions and personnel.**
 - **To enable all Central Ministries and Departments and their Organization to directly invest their resources towards co-creation and sharing the collaborative and common ecosystem of learning through an annual financial subscription for every employee.**
 - To encourage and partner with the best-in-class learning content creators including public training institutions, universities, start-tips and individual experts.
- There is no provision for lateral entry or revision of pay structures under Mission Karmayogi. **Hence statement 3 is not correct.**

Q 69.D

- **Recent context: India hosted a special meeting of Foreign Ministers of ASEAN on 15-16 June 2022.**
 - This was propelled by not only India's focus on the region for mutual economic benefits in accordance with its ACT East policy, but also its growing concern over the spiralling tension because of the increasing Chinese belligerence.
- **The Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN)** is a regional grouping that aims to promote economic and security cooperation among its ten members: **Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, and Vietnam.** ASEAN countries have a total population of 662 million people and a combined gross domestic product (GDP) of \$3.2 trillion.



- ASEAN is headed by a chair—a position that rotates annually among member states—and is assisted by a secretariat based in Jakarta, Indonesia. Formed in 1967, ASEAN united Indonesia, Malaysia, the Philippines, Singapore, and Thailand, who sought to create a common front against the spread of communism. In 1976, the members signed the Treaty of Amity and Cooperation in Southeast Asia, which emphasizes mutual respect and noninterference in other countries' affairs. In 2007, the ten members adopted the ASEAN Charter, a constitutional document that provided the grouping with legal status and an institutional framework.
- As of 2020 the socio-economic profile of ASEAN is

Country	Population	Gross domestic product (GDP)	GDP per capita
Brunei	437.5K	\$12B	\$27,443
Cambodia	16.7M	\$25.8B	\$1,544
Indonesia	273.5M	\$1.1T	\$3,870
Laos	7.3M	\$19.1B	\$2,630
Malaysia	32.4M	\$337B	\$10,412
Myanmar	54.4M	\$79.9B	\$1,468
Philippines	109.6M	\$361.5B	\$3,299
Singapore	5.7M	\$340B	\$59,798
Thailand	69.8M	\$501.6B	\$7,187
Vietnam	97.3M	\$271.2B	\$2,786

- Hence option (d) is the correct answer.

Q 70.D

- Apart from the Directives included in Part IV, there are some other Directives contained in other Parts of the Constitution. They are:
 - **Claims of SCs and STs to Services:** The claims of the members of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes shall be taken into consideration, consistently with the maintenance of efficiency of administration, in the making of appointments to services and posts in connection with the affairs of the Union or a State (Article 335 in Part XVI).
 - **Instruction in mother tongue:** It shall be the endeavour of every state and every local authority within the state to provide adequate facilities for instruction in the mother tongue at the primary stage of education to children belonging to linguistic minority groups (Article 350-A in Part XVII). Hence, option (d) is correct.
 - **Development of the Hindi Language:** It shall be the duty of the Union to promote the spread of the Hindi language and to develop it so that it may serve as a medium of expression for all the elements of the composite culture of India (Article 351 in Part XVII).
 - The above Directives are also non-jus-ticiable in nature. However, they are also given equal importance and attention by the judiciary on the ground that all parts of the constitution must be read together.

Q 71.C

- The Central Vigilance Commission (CVC) is the main agency for preventing corruption in the Central government. It was established in 1964 by an executive resolution of the Central government. Its establishment was recommended by the **Santhanam Committee** on Prevention of Corruption (1962-64).
 - Thus, originally the CVC was neither a constitutional body nor a statutory body. Later, in 2003, the Parliament enacted the **Central Vigilance Commission Act**, conferring statutory status on the CVC. Hence statement 1 is not correct.
- In 2004, the CVC has been designated as the agency to receive and act on complaints or disclosure on any allegation of corruption or misuse of office from whistle blowers under the **“Public Interest Disclosure and Protection of Informers’ Resolution” (PIDPI)**, which is popularly known as “Whistle Blowers” Resolution.
 - The Commission is also empowered as the only designated agency to take action against complainants making motivated or vexatious complaints. Hence statement 2 is correct.
 - It exercises superintendence over the functioning of the Delhi Special Police Establishment (CBI) insofar as it relates to the investigation of offences under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988. Hence statement 3 is correct.
- The CVC is a multi-member body consisting of a Central Vigilance Commissioner (chairperson) and not more than two vigilance commissioners.
 - They are **appointed by the president** by warrant under his hand and seal on the recommendation of a three-member committee consisting of the prime minister as its head, the Union minister of home affairs and the Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha.
 - They hold office for a term of four years or until they attain the age of sixty five years, whichever is earlier.
 - After their tenure, they are not eligible for further employment under the Central or a state government.
- **The president can remove the Central Vigilance Commissioner or any vigilance commissioner** from the office under the following circumstances:
 - If he is adjudged an insolvent; or
 - If he has been convicted of an offence which (in the opinion of the Central government) involves a moral turpitude; or
 - If he engages, during his term of office, in any paid employment outside the duties of his office; or
 - If he is (in the opinion of the president), unfit to continue in office by reason of infirmity of mind or body; or
 - If he has acquired such financial or other interest as is likely to affect prejudicially his official functions.
- In addition to these, the president can also remove the Central Vigilance Commissioner or any vigilance commissioner on the ground of proved misbehaviour or incapacity. However, in these cases, the president has to refer the matter to the Supreme Court for an enquiry.
- **The salary, allowances and other conditions of service of the Central Vigilance Commissioner are similar to those of the Chairman of UPSC and that of the vigilance commissioner are similar to those of a member of UPSC. But they cannot be varied to his disadvantage after his appointment.**

Q 72.B

- As per Article 279A (1) of the amended Constitution, the GST Council was constituted by the President within 60 days of the commencement of Article 279A. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- As per Article 279A of the amended Constitution, the GST Council which is a joint forum of the Centre and the States. consist of the following members: -
 - **Union Finance Minister - Chairperson. Hence statement 2 is not correct.**
 - The Union Minister of State, in-charge of Revenue of finance - Member
 - The Minister In-charge of finance or taxation or any other Minister nominated by each State Government - Members. **Hence statement 3 is not correct.**
- As per Article 279A (4), the Council will make recommendations to the Union and the States on important issues related to GST, like the goods and services that may be subjected or exempted from GST, model GST Laws, principles that govern Place of Supply, threshold limits, GST rates including the floor rates with bands, special rates for raising additional resources during natural calamities/disasters, special provisions for certain States, etc.

Q 73.D

- In early 2022, **India's first liquid-mirror telescope**, which will observe asteroids, supernovae, space debris and all other celestial objects from an altitude of 2,450 metres in the Himalayas, saw its first light as it peered into the zenith from the Devasthal observatory in Uttarakhand. It became the world's first liquid-mirror telescope to be commissioned for astronomy.
- **The International Liquid-Mirror Telescope (ILMT)** has been **set up at the Devasthal Observatory campus** owned by Aryabhata Research Institute of Observational Sciences (ARIES), Nainital in Uttarakhand. Located at 2,450 metres above mean sea level, there are two firsts with this — it's the only one to have been developed for astronomy research and is also the only one of its kind to be operational anywhere in the world. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- With ILMT set to commence full-scale scientific operations, it will work along with the 3.6-metre Devasthal Optical Telescope (DOT), the largest telescopes operating in India (of the 4-metre class). Also operating at the location is the 1.3-metre Devasthal Fast Optical Telescope (DFOT) inaugurated in 2010.
- A conventional telescope is steered to point towards the celestial source of interest in the sky for observations. **The liquid-mirror telescopes, on the other hand, are stationary telescopes that image a strip of the sky which is at the zenith at a given point of time in the night.** In other words, a liquid-mirror telescope will survey and capture any and all possible celestial objects — from stars, galaxies, supernovae explosions, asteroids to space debris.
- **India, Belgium, Canada, Poland and Uzbekistan** are the main countries who have **collaborated to set up the ILMT**. The telescope was designed and built at the Advanced Mechanical and Optical Systems Corporation and the Centre Spatial de Liège in Belgium. The funding, estimated to range between Rs 30 to Rs 40 crore, was jointly provided by Canada and Belgium. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**
- **The liquid-telescope is made up of mirrors with a reflective liquid, in this case, mercury — a metal which has a high light-reflecting capacity.** About 50 litres (equal to 700kgs) of mercury filled into a container will be rotated at a fixed constant speed along the vertical axis of the ILMT. During this process, the mercury will spread as a thin layer in the container forming a paraboloid-shaped reflecting surface which will now act as the mirror. Such a surface is ideal to collect and focus light. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- Another difference between the two is their operational time. While conventional telescopes observe specific stellar sources for fixed hours as per the study requirement and time allotted by the respective telescope time allotment committee, ILMT will capture the sky's images on all nights — between two successive twilights — for the next five years starting October 2022. For protecting it from moisture during monsoon, the ILMT will remain shut for operations between June and August.

Q 74.B

- **A citizens' charter is a document of commitments made by a government agency to the citizens in respect of the services being provided to them. Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- It empowers the citizens to demand committed standards of service. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- However, it is not legally enforceable and hence, non-justiciable. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**
- Its objective is to build bridges between citizens and administration and to streamline administration in tune with the needs and concerns of citizens.
- **A citizens' charter in India has the following components:**
 - Vision and Mission Statement of the Organisation
 - Details of Business transacted by the Organisation

- Details of citizens or clients
- Statement of services including standards, quality, time frame etc., provided to each citizen/client group separately and how/where to get the services
- Details of grievance redressal mechanism and how to access it and
- Expectations from the citizens or clients.

Q 75.A

- The Election Commission under **The Election Symbols (Reservation and Allotment) Order, 1968**, registers political parties for the purpose of the elections and grants them recognition as national or state parties on the basis of their poll performance.
- A party is recognized as a **national party** if any of the following conditions are fulfilled:
 - If it secures **six percent of valid votes** polled in any **four or more states** at a general election to the Lok Sabha or to the legislative assembly; and, in addition, it wins **four seats in the Lok Sabha** from any state or states; or
 - If it wins **two percent of seats in the Lok Sabha** at a general election; and these candidates are **elected from three states**; or
 - If it is recognized as a **state party in four states**.
- Hence, option (a) is the correct answer.

Q 76.C

- Recently, the Supreme Court had **Suo moto** opened a review of the process by which courts award the death penalty.
- The Indian Penal Code in accordance with the provisions enshrined in the Constitution of India provided for awarding of capital punishment for certain specific offences. Apart from other offences under IPC, the death penalty is also awarded under Section 31A of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances Act, it can be awarded in case of **Drug trafficking in cases of repeat offences**.
- The district judge is the highest judicial authority in the district. He possesses original and appellate jurisdiction in both civil as well as criminal matters. **The sessions judge has the power** to impose any sentence including life imprisonment and **capital punishment (death sentence)**. However, a capital punishment passed by him is subject to confirmation by the High Court, whether there is an appeal or not. **Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
- **Under Article 72** of the Constitution, the President is empowered to grant pardons, etc., and to suspend, remit or commute sentences in certain cases. It extends to cases of **Court-martial, death sentence** or matters to which executive powers of the Union extends. S/he is bound to act on the aid and advice of the Council of Ministers.
- The President can pardon death sentence while governor cannot. Even if a **state law prescribes death sentence**, the power to grant **pardon lies with the President** and not the governor. However, the governor can suspend, remit or commute a death sentence. **Hence statement 4 is not correct.**
- The Supreme Court examined the pardoning power of the President under different cases and laid down the following principles:
 - The petitioner for mercy has **no right to an oral hearing** by the President. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**
 - The power is to be exercised by the President on the advice of the union cabinet.
 - There is no need for the Supreme Court to lay down specific guidelines for the exercise of power by the President.
 - The exercise of power by the President is not subject to judicial review except where the presidential decision is arbitrary, irrational, mala fide or discriminatory.
- At present, there is **no time limit for disposing clemency pleas filed before the President**. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**

Q 77.A

- Recently, ONGC has become the first Exploration and Production (E&P) company in India to trade domestic gas on Indian Gas Exchange. Indian Gas Exchange Ltd. (IGX) is India's first automated national level Gas Exchange to promote and sustain an efficient and robust Gas market and to foster gas trading in the country.
- **IGX allows buyers and sellers of natural gas to trade both in spot market and in forward market for imported natural gas.** IGX is a neutral and transparent market place where both buyers and sellers trade Gas as the underlying commodity. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**

- **Trading is allowed across three hubs —Dahej and Hazira in Gujarat, and Kakinada in Andhra Pradesh.**
- The contracts traded at Exchange are for compulsory specific physical delivery and settlement of the trade are subject to the condition that such contracts are non-transferable in nature and without any netting-off thereby.
- IGX enables efficient and competitive discovery of gas prices and one of its most important objectives is also to maintain market integrity. IGX started operations on 15th June 2020 as Gas Trading Platform and has been operating as the Gas Exchange since 10th December 2020.
- **The Exchange operates under the regulatory framework of the Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board (PNGRB). Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 78.D

- Article 324 of the Constitution of India provides for the office of the Election Commission. In order to safeguard and ensure its independent and impartial functioning, the Constitution has provided following safeguards:
- The Chief Election Commissioner is provided with the security of tenure. He cannot be removed from his office except in the same manner and on the same grounds as a judge of the Supreme Court.
- **The service conditions of the Chief Election Commissioner cannot be varied to his disadvantage after his appointment. Hence statement 2 is correct.**
- Any other election commissioner or a regional commissioner cannot be removed from office except on the recommendation of the Chief Election Commissioner.
- **However, the independent functioning of the Commission can be limited due to following reasons:**
- The Constitution has not prescribed the qualifications for the members of the Election Commission. **Hence statement 1 is correct**
- **The Constitution has not debarred the retiring election commissioners from any further appointment by the government. Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- The Constitution has not specified the term of the members of the Election Commission.

Q 79.C

- **Originally, the Constitution of India did not make any provision with respect to the Special Officer for Linguistic Minorities.** Later, the States Reorganisation Commission (1953–55) made a recommendation in this regard. Accordingly, the Seventh Constitutional Amendment Act of 1956 inserted a new Article 350-B in Part XVII of the Constitution.
- This article contains the following provisions:
 - **There should be a Special Officer for Linguistic Minorities. He is to be appointed by the President of India.**
 - It would be the duty of the Special Officer to investigate all matters relating to the safeguards provided for linguistic minorities under the Constitution. He would report to the President upon those matters at such intervals as the President may direct. The President should place all such reports before each House of Parliament and send to the governments of the states concerned.
 - **The Constitution does not specify the qualifications, tenure, salaries and allowances, service conditions and procedure for removal of the Special Officer for Linguistic Minorities. Hence, statement 1 is not correct.**
 - **At the Central level, the Commissioner falls under the Ministry of Minority Affairs.** Hence, he submits the annual reports or other reports to the President through the Union Minority Affairs Minister. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**
- **Functions**
 - **To investigate all matters related to safeguards provided to the linguistic minorities. Hence, statement 3 is correct.**
 - To submit to the President of India, the reports on the status of implementation of the Constitutional and the nationally agreed safeguards for the linguistic minorities
 - To monitor the implementation of safeguards through questionnaires, visits, conferences, seminars, meetings, review mechanism, etc.

Q 80.B

- **Election Commission of India (ECI) has the power to register parties under the Representation of the People Act, (RPA) 1951, but it does not have the power to deregister parties that are inactive.** A party can only be de-registered if its registration was **obtained by fraud**; if it is **declared illegal by the Central**

Government; or if a party amends its internal Constitution and notifies the ECI that it can no longer abide by the Indian Constitution. Hence, statement 1 is not correct.

- Once recognised as a national or a state party, a political party retains that status irrespective of its performance in the next elections. It **loses the given status** only if it **fails to fulfil any of the conditions for two successive** Assembly and two successive Lok Sabha elections.
- **A party is recognized as a state party if any of the following conditions are fulfilled:**
 - If it secures 6% of the valid votes polled in the state at a general election to the legislative assembly of the state concerned and in addition, it wins 2 seats in the assembly of the state concerned or
 - If it secures 6% of the valid votes polled in the state at a general election to the Lok Sabha from the state concerned and in addition, it wins 1 seat in the Lok Sabha from the state concerned or
 - If it wins 3% of seats in the legislative assembly at a general election to the legislative assembly of the state concerned or 3 seats in the assembly, whichever is more or
 - If it wins 1 seat in the Lok Sabha for every 25 seats or any fraction thereof allotted to the state at a general election to the Lok Sabha from the state concerned or
 - **If it secures 8% of the total valid votes polled in the state at a General Election to the Lok Sabha from the state or to the legislative assembly of the state. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**

Q 81.A

- The 52nd Amendment Act of 1985 provided for the disqualification of the members of Parliament and the state legislatures on the ground of defection from one political party to another. For this purpose, it made changes in four Articles of the Constitution and added a new Schedule (the Tenth Schedule) to the Constitution. This act is often referred to as the anti-defection law.
- Any question regarding disqualification arising out of defection is to be decided by the presiding officer of the House. Originally, the act provided that the decision of the presiding officer is final and cannot be questioned in any court. However, in the Kihoto Hollohan case (1993), the Supreme Court declared this provision as unconstitutional on the ground that it seeks to take away the jurisdiction of the Supreme Court and the high courts. It held that the presiding officer, while deciding a question under the Tenth Schedule, functions as a tribunal. Hence, his decision like that of any other tribunal is subject to judicial review on the grounds of mala fides, perversity, etc. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- According to the rules made so, the presiding officer can take up a defection case only when he receives a complaint from a member of the House. Before taking the final decision, he must give the member (against whom the complaint has been made) a chance to submit his explanation. He may also refer the matter to the committee of privileges for inquiry. Hence, defection has no immediate and automatic effect. Thus he cannot take the matter suo moto. **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**

Q 82.C

- Recently, Kolkata became first major metropolitan city to prepare a detailed register of biodiversity i.e. People's Biodiversity Register (PBR).
- **The Biological Diversity Act (BDA), 2002** has made it mandatory for every local self-governing institution in rural and urban areas to constitute Biodiversity Management Committee (BMC) within their area of jurisdiction. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- The mandate of the **Biodiversity Management Committee** has been clearly highlighted in the **Biological Diversity Rules 2002** is to prepare People's Biodiversity Register in consultation with the local people. **Hence, statement 2 is not correct.**
 - The National Biodiversity Authority shall provide guidance and technical support to the Biodiversity Management Committee (BMC) for preparing People's Biodiversity Register.
 - The State Biodiversity Board (SBB) would provide necessary training to the Technical Support Group (TSG) of the district and enable smooth functioning and aid in networking for creation and maintenance of People's Biodiversity Registers (PBRs).
- The Register shall contain comprehensive information on availability and knowledge of **local biological resources, their medicinal or any other use. Hence, statement 3 is correct.**
 - The guidelines related to PBRs:
 - ✓ It is to be undertaken in a participatory mode involving varying sections of village society.
 - ✓ While documenting, the knowledge and views of both genders are to be recorded.
 - ✓ Information provided by people need to be collated, analysed and crosschecked by the members of the Technical Support Group (TSG) before documentation.
 - ✓ The PBR is important base document in the legal arena as evidence of prior knowledge and hence careful documentation is necessary.

- ✓ The document should be endorsed by the BMC and later publicized in the Gram Sabha / Gram Panchayat / Panchayat Samiti. The document can be a very useful tool in the management and sustainable use of bioresources. The document can also be a very useful teaching tool for teaching environmental studies at schools, colleges and university level
- ✓ The document should be periodically updated with additional and new information as and when generated.

Q 83.B

- **Recently, WTO members reached a provisional deal to extend electronic transmission moratorium until the next ministerial meeting, likely to be in 2023.**
 - **Electronic transmission moratorium seeks to not impose any customs duty on electronic transmissions.**
- The prospect of ending the moratorium, which has exempted data flows from cross-border tariffs since 1998, had raised major concerns among businesses. Backed by major players like the United States, the United Kingdom and the European Union, they argued that letting it expire would undermine a global recovery already threatened by spiralling prices.
- India opposed extension on grounds that developing countries have been losing revenue. Since digital trade at present is dominated by big tech and developed countries, the moratorium squarely favours the developed nations.
- **Hence option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 84.D

- **Articles 294 to 300 in Part XII of the Constitution** deal with the property, contracts, rights, liabilities, obligations and suits of the Union and the states. In this regard, the Constitution makes the Union or the states as juristic (legal) persons.
- The Constitution confers certain immunities to the president of India and governor of states with regard to their official acts and personal acts. These are:
 - **Official Acts**
 - ✓ The president and the governors cannot be sued during the term of their office or thereafter, for any act done by them in the exercise and performance of their official powers and duties. However, the official conduct of the president can be reviewed by a court, tribunal or any other body authorised by either House of Parliament to investigate charges for impeachment.
 - **Personal Acts**
 - ✓ No criminal proceedings can be started against the president and the governors in respect of their personal acts nor can they be arrested or imprisoned. This immunity is limited to the period of the term of their office only and does not extend beyond that. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**
 - **Ministers**
 - ✓ The Constitution does not grant any immunity to the ministers for their official acts. But, since they are not required to countersign (as in Britain) the official acts of the president and the governors, they are not liable in the courts for those acts. **Hence, statement 4 is correct.**
 - **Judicial Officers**
 - ✓ The judicial officers enjoy immunity from any liability in respect of their official acts and hence, cannot be sued. The Judicial Officers Protection Act (1850) lays down that, 'no judge, magistrate, justice of peace, collector or other person acting judicially shall be liable to be sued in any civil court for any act done by him in the discharge of his official duty'. **Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- **In Common Cause Case, the Supreme Court said** that in modern times when the State activities have been considerably increased it is very difficult to draw a line between its sovereign and non-sovereign functions. The increased activities of the State have made a deep impression on all facets of citizens' life, and therefore, the liability of the State must be made coextensive with the modern concept of a welfare State. **The State must be liable for all tortuous acts of its employees, whether done in exercise of sovereign or non-sovereign powers. Hence, statement 3 is correct.**

Q 85.C

- **National Skill Development Corporation (NSDC) is a not-for-profit public limited company incorporated** on July 31, 2008 under section 25 of the Companies Act, 1956 (corresponding to section 8 of the Companies Act, 2013).
 - NSDC was set up as part of a national skill development mission to fulfil the growing need in India for skilled manpower across sectors and narrow the existing gap between the demand and supply of skills. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**

- NSDC was set up by **Ministry of Finance** as Public Private Partnership (PPP) model. **Hence statement 2 is correct.** The Government of India through **Ministry of Skill Development & Entrepreneurship (MSDE)** holds 49% of the share capital of NSDC, while the private sector has the balance 51% of the share capital. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- NSDC aims to promote skill development by catalyzing creation of large, quality and for-profit vocational institutions. Further, the organisation provides funding to build scalable and profitable vocational training initiatives.
 - Its mandate is also to enable support system which focuses on quality assurance, information systems and train the trainer academies either directly or through partnerships.
 - NSDC acts as a catalyst in skill development by providing funding to enterprises, companies and organizations that provide skill training. It also develops appropriate models to enhance, support and coordinate private sector initiatives. The differentiated focus on 37 sectors under NSDC's purview and its understanding of their viability will make every sector attractive to private investment.

Q 86.B

- **Articles 323 A and 323 B differs in the following three aspects:**
 - While **Article 323 A** contemplates establishment of tribunals for **public service matters (Union and states)** only, **Article 323 B** contemplates establishment of tribunals for certain other matters namely:
 - ✓ levy, assessment, collection and **enforcement of any tax**;
 - ✓ **foreign exchange**, import and export across customs frontiers;
 - ✓ **industrial and labour disputes**;
 - ✓ land reforms by way of acquisition by the State of any estate, ceiling on urban property;
 - ✓ **elections to either House of Parliament** or the House or either House of the Legislature of a State
 - ✓ production, procurement, supply and distribution of food-stuffs
 - ✓ rent, its regulation and control and tenancy issues
 - ✓ **Hence option (b) is the correct answer.**
 - While tribunals under Article 323 A can be established only by Parliament, **tribunals under Article 323 B can be established both by Parliament and state legislatures with respect to matters falling within their legislative competence.**
 - Under Article 323 A, only one tribunal for the Centre and one for each state or two or more states may be established.
 - **There is no question of hierarchy of tribunals under Article 323A, whereas under Article 323 B a hierarchy of tribunals may be created.**
 - In Chandra Kumar case (1997), the Supreme Court declared those provisions of these two articles which excluded the jurisdiction of the high courts and the Supreme Court as unconstitutional. Hence, the judicial remedies are now available against the orders of these tribunals.

Q 87.B

- In exercise of the powers conferred by Section 11 of the **State Emblem of India (Prohibition of Improper Use) Act, 2005**, the Central Government made the following rules regulating the use of the State Emblem of India in official seal and on stationery and its design, namely :
- **Design of the official seal:**
 - The design of the Official Seal shall have the emblem enclosed in an oval or round frame.
 - The name of the Ministry or the office shall appear between the inner and outer rims of the frame.
 - The abbreviated form of the name of a Ministry or the office may be inscribed where it is not possible to accommodate the name in full.
- **Adoption by States or Union territories:**
 - A State Government may adopt the emblem as the official Emblem of the State or the Union territory, as the case may be, without obtaining the approval of the Central Government. **Hence statement 1 is not correct.**
 - Where a State Government proposes to incorporate the **emblem or any part thereof in the Emblem of that State** or Union territory, as the case may be, it shall do so after obtaining the prior approval of the Central Government and shall get the design and lay out approved by the Central Government.
- **Use in official seals:**
 - The use of the emblem in official seal shall be restricted to the **Constitutional or Statutory** Authorities, Ministries or Departments of the Central Government, State Governments or Union Territory Administrations and other Government Functionaries such as:
 - ✓ Commissions and authorities, constituted or established by an Act of Parliament or set up by the Central Government;

- ✓ Commissions and authorities constituted or established by an Act of the State Legislature or set up by the State Government, if the emblem is adopted by, or incorporated in the Emblem of, that State or the Union territory;
- ✓ **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**
- **Display on public buildings:**
 - The emblem may be displayed on very important public buildings, like, the Rashtrapati Bhawan, Parliament House, Supreme Court and Central Secretariat buildings.
 - The emblem may be displayed on Raj Bhawan or Raj Niwas and State Legislature, High Courts and Secretariat buildings of the States or the Union Territories that have adopted the emblem or have incorporated the emblem in the Emblem of the State or the Union Territory.
 - The emblem may be displayed on the premises of India's Diplomatic Mission abroad and the heads of Missions may display the emblem at their residences in the countries of their accreditation.
 - The emblem may be displayed on the buildings occupied by India's Consulates abroad at the entrance doors thereof and on the residences of Heads of consular posts in the countries of their accreditation.
- **Restriction on the use of the emblem:**
 - No person (including former functionaries of the Government, like, former Ministers, former Members of Parliament, former Members of Legislative Assemblies, former judges and retired Government officials), other than those authorised under these rules, shall use the emblem in any manner.
 - **No Commission or Committee, Public Sector Undertaking, Bank, Municipal Council, Panchayat Raj Institution, Parishad, non-government organisation, University, other than those authorised under these rules, shall use the emblem in any manner. Hence statement 3 is correct.**
 - No association or body of persons, whether incorporated or not, shall use the emblem on their letter-heads, brochures, seats, crests, badges, house flags or for any other purpose in any manner.
 - The stationery, including letter heads, visiting cards and greeting cards, with emblem printed or embossed on it, shall not bear words, like, Advocate, Editor, Chartered Accountant with the name of the person authorised to use the emblem under these rules on the stationery.

Q 88.B

- Through **Artemis Accords**, NASA aims to land the first woman and first person of color on the Moon, heralding a new era for space exploration and utilization. With numerous countries and private sector players conducting missions and operations in cislunar space, it's critical to establish a common set of principles to govern the civil exploration and use of outer space.
- **The Artemis Accords will describe a shared vision for principles, grounded in the Outer Space Treaty of 1967. The purpose of these Artemis Accords is to establish a common vision via a practical set of principles, guidelines, and best practices to enhance the governance of the civil exploration and use of outer space with the intention of advancing the Artemis Program.**
- The principles set out in these Accords are intended to **apply to civil space activities** conducted by the civil space agencies of each **Signatory. These activities may take place on the Moon, Mars, comets, and asteroids**, including their surfaces and subsurfaces, as well as in orbit of the Moon or Mars, in the Lagrangian points for the Earth-Moon system, and in **transit between these celestial bodies and locations.**
- **Hence option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 89.C

- Recently, **Brazilian scientists warn that Pantanal**, freshwater wetland, is at risk of collapse.
 - Pantanal in South America, is one of the world's largest tropical wetland.
 - It spans over 179,000 sq. km in **Brazil, Paraguay and Bolivia. Hence, pair 1 is correctly matched.**
 - It consists of highest concentrations of flora and fauna in South America.
 - In 2000, it was inscribed on UNESCO's World Heritage List.
- Lake Victoria, also called Victoria Nyanza is the largest lake in Africa and is chief reservoir of the Nile. It is located mainly in **Tanzania and Uganda** but is **bordering on Kenya. Hence, pair 2 is not correctly matched.**
 - Its waters fill a shallow depression in the centre of the great plateau that stretches between the Western and Eastern Rift Valleys. This lake provides water for countries along the River Nile. Egypt and Sudan have managed to maximise on water flowing out from Lake Victoria. Some of the tributaries that fill out water into Lake Victoria from water catchment areas are from the Great Rift Valley and western Kenya.

- **Lake Balkhash, the largest lake in Central Asia, is situated in east-central Kazakhstan.** The lake's size varies depending on water balance, with its area fluctuating from around 15,000 sq km to 19,000 sq km. **Hence, pair 3 is correctly matched.**
 - Jutting out into the lake is the Sarymsek Peninsula which divides Balkhash into two separate hydraulic parts. The west part is wide and shallow with its water on this side particularly fresh and suitable for drinking. The east part, on the other hand, is narrow and relatively deep, with its waters on this side of the basin brackish and salty. The two parts of the lake are united by a narrow strait, the **Uzynaral**.

Q 90.A

- The Constitution (Article 165) has provided for the office of the advocate general for the states. He is the highest law officer in the state. Thus he corresponds to the Attorney General of India.
- **The advocate general is appointed by the governor. He must be a person who is qualified to be appointed a judge of a high court.** In other words, he must be a citizen of India and must have held a judicial office for ten years or been an advocate of a high court for ten years. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- **The term of office of the advocate general is not fixed by the Constitution. Further, the Constitution does not contain the procedure and grounds for his removal.** He holds office during the pleasure of the governor. This means that he may be removed by the governor at any time. He may also quit his office by submitting his resignation to the governor. **Hence statement 3 is correct.**
- Conventionally, he resigns when the government (council of ministers) resigns or is replaced, as he is appointed on its advice.
- **The remuneration of the advocate general is not fixed by the Constitution.** He receives such remuneration as the governor may determine.
- In the performance of his official duties, the advocate general is entitled to appear before any court of law within the state. Further, he has the right to speak and to take part in the proceedings of both the Houses of the state legislature or any committee of the state legislature of which he may be named a member, but without a right to vote. **He enjoys all the privileges and immunities that are available to a member of the state legislature. Hence statement 2 is correct.**

Q 91.C

- **E-Governance or electronic governance implies the application of Information and Communications Technology (ICT) to government functioning.**
- According to the World Bank, e-governance refers to the use by government agencies of information technologies (such as Wide Area Networks, the Internet, and mobile computing) that have the ability to transform relations with citizens, businesses, and other arms of government.
- e-Governance is basically a move towards SMART governance implying: simple, moral, accountable, responsive and transparent governance.
- **The benefits of e-Governance are as follows:**
 - Better delivery of government services to citizens
 - Improved interactions with business and industry
 - Citizen empowerment through access to information
 - More efficient government management
 - **Less corruption in the administration. Hence option 1 is correct.**
 - Increased transparency in administration
 - Greater convenience to citizens and businesses
 - Cost reductions and revenue growth
 - Increased legitimacy of government
 - **Flattens organisational structure (less hierarchic). Hence option 2 is not correct.**
 - Reduced paperwork and red tapism in the administrative process
 - Better planning and coordination between different levels of governance
 - **Greater citizen participation in the governance process. Hence option 3 is correct.**
 - **Improved relations between the public authorities and civil society. Hence option 4 is correct.**
 - Restructuring of administrative processes

Q 92.D

- **In the context of rising petrol and diesel prices in India, central government has slashed excise duty on petrol and diesel by Rs 8 and Rs 6 per litre respectively bringing down the retail prices across India.**
- Taxes make up around 50% of the retail price of petrol and diesel in India. Public sector Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs) revise the retail prices of petrol and diesel in India on a daily basis, according to

changes in the price of global crude oil. The price charged to dealers includes the base price set by OMCs and the freight price.

- **The primary components of petrol and diesel retail price in India are**
 - **Price Charged to Dealers**
 - **Excise Duty (levied by centre)**
 - **Dealer Commission**
 - **Sales Tax/ VAT (levied by state/union territories)**
- There are four components of Central Excise Duty on petrol and diesel.
 - Basic Excise Duty
 - Special Additional Excise Duty
 - Agriculture Infrastructure & Development Cess (AIDC)
 - Road and Infrastructure Cess
- While excise duty rates are uniform across the country, states levy sales tax/ Value Added Tax (VAT) which varies across states. For instance, Odisha levies 32% VAT on petrol, while Uttar Pradesh levies 26.8% VAT.
- **Unlike excise duty, sales tax is an ad valorem tax, i.e., it does not have a fixed value, and is charged as a percentage of the price of the product. This implies that while the value of the excise duty component of the price structure is fixed, the value of the sales tax component is dependent on the other three components, i.e., price charged to dealers, dealer commission, and excise duty.**
- India's dependence on imports for consumption of petroleum products has increased over the years. For instance, in 1998-99, net imports of petroleum products were 69% of the total consumption, which increased to around 95% in 2020-21.
- **Hence option (d) is the correct answer.**

Q 93.B

- Various committees and commissions have examined our electoral system and suggested reforms. Some of the reforms undertaken by the Government are as follows:
- **Lowering the voting age by the 61st Constitutional Amendment Act 1988**, reduced the voting age from 21 years to 18 years for Lok Sabha as well as the assembly elections.
- The Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) were used for the first time in 1998 on an experimental basis in selected constituencies in the elections to the Assemblies of Rajasthan, Madhyamgram Pradesh, and Delhi.
- **Electors Photo Identity Card (EPIC) was issued to voters in 1993.**
- Facility to opt to vote through Proxy was provided to service voters i.e. voters belonging to the armed forces in the year 2003.
- **None of the Above (NOTA)** was introduced during the general elections to the State Legislative Assemblies of Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Mizoram, Delhi, and Rajasthan in the year **2013**.
- **Photos of candidates on EVMs and ballot papers were introduced in the year 2015 by the Election Commission of India.**
- **Hence option (b) is the correct answer.**

Q 94.D

- **Amid China's aggressive push to increase its Pacific sphere of influence, the US and its allies — Australia, New Zealand, Japan and the United Kingdom — have launched a new initiative called 'Partners in the Blue Pacific' (PBP) for "effective and efficient cooperation" with the region's small island nations.**
- **The PBP is a five-nation "informal mechanism" to support Pacific islands** and to boost diplomatic, economic ties in the region. It speaks of enhancing "prosperity, resilience, and security" in the Pacific through closer cooperation. It simply means that through the PBP, these countries — together and individually — **will direct more resources here to counter China's aggressive outreach.**
- The geostrategic competition in the region has intensified of late after China made the projected scope of its growing footprint clear by pushing for a sweeping, common cooperation agreement with 10 Pacific nations.
- The initiative members have also declared that they will "elevate Pacific regionalism", and forge stronger ties with the **Pacific Islands Forum**.
 - The Pacific Islands Forum is an inter-governmental organization that aims to enhance cooperation between countries and territories of the Pacific Ocean, including the formation of a trade bloc and regional peacekeeping operations. Founded: 1971, Headquarters location: Suva, Fiji.
- **Hence option (d) is the correct answer.**

Q 95.D

- The National Human Rights Commission is a statutory (and not a constitutional) body. It was established in 1993 under a legislation enacted by the Parliament, namely, the Protection of Human Rights Act, 1993. This Act was amended in 2006 and 2019.
- The commission is a multi-member body consisting of a chairman and four members.
 - **The chairman should be a retired chief justice of India or a judge of Supreme Court.**
 - Under the original act, only a person who has been a Chief Justice of the Supreme Court can be the chairperson of the NHRC. But the 2019 amendment provided that a person who has been Chief Justice of the Supreme Court, or a Judge of the Supreme Court can be the chairperson of the NHRC.
 - One members should be serving or retired judges of the Supreme Court.
 - One member serving or retired chief justice of a high court and
 - Three members out of which at least one women to be appointed from amongst persons having knowledge or practical experience with respect to human rights.
- The chairman and members are appointed by the president on the recommendations of a six-member committee consisting of the prime minister as its head, the Speaker of the Lok Sabha, the Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha, leaders of the Opposition in both the Houses of Parliament and the Central home minister.
 - Further, a sitting judge of the Supreme Court or a sitting chief justice of a high court can be appointed only after consultation with the chief justice of India.
- The chairman and members hold office for a **term of three years** or until they attain the **age of 70 years**, whichever is earlier. After their tenure, the chairman and members are not eligible for further employment under the Central or a state government.
- The original Act states that the chairperson and members of the NHRC and SHRC will hold office for five years or till the age of seventy years, whichever is earlier. The 2019 amendment reduced the term of office to three years or till the age of seventy years, whichever is earlier.
- **It can inquire** into any violation of human rights or negligence in the prevention of such violation by a public servant, either **suo motu** or on a petition presented to it or on an order of a court.
- **It is vested with the power to regulate its own procedure. It has all the powers of a civil court and its proceedings have a judicial character.** It may call for information or report from the Central and state governments or any other authority subordinate thereto.
- **Hence option (d) is the correct answer.**

Q 96.D

- Recently, RBI notified the market making scheme to promote retail participation in government securities by providing prices/quotes to retail direct gilt (RDG) account holders enabling them to buy and sell securities under the Retail Direct Scheme. According to media reports, barely Rs 96 crore worth of government securities (G-Secs) have been purchased through this platform between November 2021 and April 2022.
- About Retail Direct scheme
 - It is a one-stop solution to facilitate investment in Government Securities by **Individual Investors**.
 - ✓ Term retail investor refers to individual investors or retail traders. These are non-professional investors who purchase assets such as stocks, bonds, securities, mutual funds, and exchange traded funds (ETFs).
 - Under the scheme, **retail investors can buy G-Sec directly in the primary markets** and free of cost. Earlier investors could buy government securities through gilt mutual funds. The scheme provides the following facilities to retail investors in government securities market through an online portal:
 - ✓ **Open and maintain a 'Retail Direct Gilt Account' (RDG Account):** Under this scheme individual retail investors can open a Gilt Securities Account – "Retail Direct Gilt (RDG)" account with **RBI. Hence, option (d) is the correct answer.**
 - ✓ Access to primary issuance of Government securities
 - ✓ Access to NDS-OM.
 - **Non-Resident retail investors eligible to invest in Government Securities** under Foreign Exchange Management Act, 1999 are also eligible under the scheme.
 - **Primary market participation:** Participation and allotment of securities will be as per the non-competitive scheme for participation in primary auction of government securities.
 - Secondary market transaction: **Registered investors** can access the **secondary market transaction** link on the online portal to buy or sell government securities through NDS-OM (odd lot segment/RFQ).

- Under the scheme, **Clearing Corporation of India Limited (CCIL)** has been permitted to **aggregate the bids received from 'Retail investors'** in a non-competitive segment of primary auctions of Government Securities and Treasury Bills.

Q 97.C

- The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) is the central recruiting agency in India. It is an independent constitutional body in the sense that it has been directly created by the Constitution. Part XIV in the Article 315 to 323 of the Indian Constitution deals with the appointment of UPSC members, functions and powers of UPSC.
- The UPSC consists of a chairman and other members appointed by the president of India.
- **The Constitution, without specifying the strength of the Commission has left the matter to the discretion of the president**, who determines its composition.
- Further, no qualifications are prescribed for the Commission's membership except that one-half of the members of the Commission should be such persons who have held office for at least ten years either under the Government of India or under the government of a state.
- **The Constitution also authorises the president to determine** the conditions of service of the chairman and other members of the Commission.
- The chairman and members of the Commission hold office for a term of six years or until they attain the age of 65 years, whichever is earlier. However, they can relinquish their offices at any time by addressing their resignation to the president.
- The President can remove the chairman or any other member of UPSC from the office under the following circumstances:
 - If he is adjudged an insolvent (that is, has gone bankrupt);
 - If he engages, during his term of office, in any paid employment outside the duties of his office; or
 - If he is, in the opinion of the president, unfit to continue in office by reason of infirmity of mind or body.
- In addition to these, the president can also remove the chairman or any other member of UPSC for misbehaviour. However, in this case, the president has to refer the matter to the Supreme Court for an enquiry. If the Supreme Court, after the enquiry, upholds the cause of removal and advises so, the president can remove the chairman or a member.
 - Under the provisions of the Constitution, the **advise tendered by the Supreme Court in this regard is binding** on the president. During the course of enquiry by the Supreme Court, the president can suspend the chairman or the member of UPSC.
- **The entire expenses including the salaries, allowances and pensions** of the chairman and members of the UPSC are charged on the Consolidated Fund of India. Thus, they are not subject to vote of Parliament. **Hence option (c) is the correct answer.**

Q 98.C

- Recently, the **first International Migration Review Forum (IMRF)** is was held (India participated) under the auspices of General Assembly at the United Nations. IMRF shall take place every four years beginning in 2022.
- IMRF will serve as primary intergovernmental global platform to discuss and share progress on implementation of all aspects pertaining to migration and its intersection with Sustainable Development Goals. It will result in adoption of an intergovernmentally agreed Progress Declaration. Member States also agreed to review the progress made at the local, national, regional and global levels in implementing the **Global Compact for Migration (GCM) at International Migration Review Forum (IMRF)** through a State-led approach and with the participation of all relevant stakeholders at the United Nations General Assembly.
- In **2016** Heads of State and Government came together for the first time ever at the global level within the UN General Assembly to discuss issues related to migration and refugees. This resulted in adopting the **New York Declaration for Refugees and Migrants and the 193 UN Member States recognized the need for a comprehensive approach to human mobility and enhanced cooperation at the global level.**
- **Annex II of the New York Declaration** set in motion a process of intergovernmental consultations and negotiations towards the development of a Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration. This process concluded in **December 2018 with the adoption of the Global Compact for Migration** by the majority of UN Member States at an Intergovernmental Conference in Marrakesh, Morocco, followed closely by formal endorsement by the UN General Assembly. **The Global Compact is the first inter-governmentally negotiated agreement**, prepared under the auspices of the United Nations, covering all

dimensions of international migration in a holistic and comprehensive manner. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**

- **The Global Compact** is framed in a way **consistent with target 10.7 of the 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development** in which Member States committed to cooperate internationally to facilitate safe, orderly and regular migration. **It is a non-binding document that respects states' sovereign right to determine who enters and stays in their territory and demonstrates commitment to international cooperation on migration.** It presents a significant opportunity to improve the governance of migration, to address the challenges associated with today's migration, and to strengthen the contribution of migrants and migration to sustainable development. **Hence statement 2 is correct.**

Q 99.C

- **Recently (January 2022), the election expenditure limit** for candidates has been **hiked to Rs 95 lakh** from Rs 70 lakh for **Lok Sabha elections** and to **Rs 40 lakh** from Rs 28 lakh for **assembly polls** by the Election Commission.
- Election expenditure is the amount an election candidate can legally spend for their election campaign and has to account for, which includes expenses on public meetings, rallies, advertisements, posters, banners, vehicles and advertisements.
- Under **Section 77 of the Representation of the People Act (RPA), 1951**, every candidate shall keep a separate and correct account of all expenditure incurred between the date on which they have been nominated and the date of declaration of the result.
- **An incorrect account or expenditure beyond the cap can lead to disqualification** of the candidate by the ECI **for up to three years, under Section 10A of RPA, 1951. Hence, statement 2 is correct.**
- There is **no cap on a political party's expenditure**, which is often exploited by candidates of the party. However, all registered political parties have to submit a statement of their election expenditure to the ECI within 90 days of the completion of the elections. **Hence, statement 1 is correct.**

Q 100.A

- Under Engineering, Procurement, and Construction (EPC) Model, the **cost is completely borne by the government.** Government invites bids for engineering knowledge from private players. Procurement of raw materials and construction costs are met by the government. **Hence statement 1 is correct.**
- Under the EPC model the contractor is legally responsible to complete the project under some fixed predetermined timeline and may also involve scope for a penalty in case of time overrun.
- In EPC as all the clearances, land acquisition and regulatory norms have to be completed by the government itself and the private players do not have to get themselves involved in these time taking procedures.
- The private sector's participation is minimum and is limited to the provision of engineering expertise. A difficulty of the model is the high financial burden on the government.
 - The private player has no role in the road's ownership, toll collection or maintenance (it is taken care of by the government). **Hence statement 2 is not correct.**